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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: KABIN ADHIKARI/TRN

Federal Parliament buildings under construction in Singha Durbar.

Govt forms panel to probe power tariff arrears

NEA instructed to reconnect disconnected lines

CABINET DECISIONS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 9

The government has decided to form a probe committee to resolve the electricity tariff dispute of dedicated feeders and trunk lines.

A meeting of the Council of Ministers held at the Office of Prime Minister and Council of Ministers in Singha Durbar on Tuesday decided to form the committee headed by former Supreme Court judge Girish Chandra Lal.

Jiblal Bhusal, Joint Secretary of the Ministry of Industry, and a Joint Secretary from the Ministry of Energy (who will be named later) will be the members of the committee.

Speaking to journalists after the Cabinet meeting, Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma said that the Cabinet meeting has further decided to give direction to the Nepal Electricity Authority (NTA) to reconnect the lines of different industries.

The NEA has started to cut off the electricity supply of industries having electricity arrears since December 22, 2023.

The Authority has cut the lines of 24 industries with arrears of more than Rs. 50 million.

Out of this, Himal Steel has paid the outstanding amount in installments and after paying the first installment, the Authority has reconnected the line.

According to the Authority, 61 industries have to pay Rs. 22.24 billion in arrears.

Industrialists and workers have also been protesting against the cutting of power lines.

Similarly, the government has endorsed the resignation tendered by Chairman of the Nepal Telecommunication Authority (NTA) Purushottam Khanal and appointed Nabaraj Adhikari, a member of the Authority, as Acting Chairman for the vacant post as per Rule 3 'A' of the Telecommunication Regulations until further arrangements are made.

Likewise, the Cabinet meeting decided to nominate 25 members in the National Development Council from among the officials/persons of various district coordination committees, local levels, and various agencies nominated by the government.

Minister Sharma said that the meeting has also decided to publish the names of martyrs whose names were skipped from being published earlier in the Nepal Gazette and announce additional martyrs by correcting the details of the martyrs.

PM INSTRUCTS LABOUR MINISTRY TO PROVIDE SERVICES AT LOCAL LEVELS



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 9

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has instructed the Ministry of Labour, Employment and Social Security to take necessary steps to issue labour permits from the local levels.

Acknowledging how troublesome it was for people to come to the capital for the smallest of procedures, Prime Minister Prachanda asked the ministry to provide as many labour services as possible from the local levels.

He also asked the ministry to update the Foreign Employment Management Information System (FEMIS) and allow Nepali missions abroad, foreign employers and workers and all 753 local governments to access it.

NMB, HIDCL to foot 70% cost for Upper Modi hydro

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 9

A tripartite loan agreement for the project was signed between promoters of the project, Modi Hydropower Company Limited, NMB Bank and HIDCL.

The financial management of the 42-megawatt Upper Modi A hydropower project to be constructed in Annapurna Rural Municipality of Kaski through the subsidiary company of Nepal Electricity Authority has been completed.

The estimated cost of the project, including interest during the construction period, is Rs. 10.57 billion, 70 per cent of which has to be raised from debt and 30 per cent from equity.

The amount under the equity will be invested by the NEA and the general public.

NMB Bank and Hydroelectricity Investment and Development Company Limited (HIDCL) will invest Rs. 7.4 billion in the project through co-financing with interest during the construction period.

Out of the total loan, NMB Bank will invest Rs. 4.4 billion and HIDCL of Rs. 3 billion.

A tripartite loan agreement for the project was signed between promoters of the project, Modi Hydropower Company Limited, NMB Bank and HIDCL in the presence of the Minister of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Shakti Basnet on Monday evening.

On the occasion, Minister Basnet said that the government was working with clear guidelines to increase domestic consumption of electricity and to sell the surplus electricity to India and Bangladesh.

He said that the export of 10,000 megawatts of electricity to the Indian market has been ensured in 10 years, and now the work is being carried forward with special attention to the increase in production and domestic consumption and export.

Kul Man Ghising, Managing Director of the NEA and Chairman of Modi Hydropower Company, said that in the coming days, Nepal's hydropower development will gain a new height.

"Through the Authority, the construction of projects with 3-digit capacity is now progressing to 4-digit capacity, and the financial management of the 1,061-megawatt Upper Arun and 635 megawatt Dudhkoshi reservoir hydropower project are to be carried out by 2024," Ghising said.

About 16,000 megawatts of projects through the Authority and its subsidiary companies are at the stage of study, construction and investment management, he said.

Chief Executive Officer of HIDCL Arjun Gautam emphasised that the common understanding that government projects are not completed on time should be proven wrong by completing the construction of the project on time.

He said that the company is ready to meet the government's target of producing 28,500 megawatts of electricity by 2035.

Sunil KC, CEO of NMB Bank, said that it is a historic opportunity and a milestone for private banks to invest in the project advanced by the Authority.

The target is to complete the construction of Upper Modi A hydroelectric project within four years from the start of construction. So far, the preparatory work for the project is being done.

The evaluation of the technical proposal submitted by the bidder for the civil and hydromechanical works under Phase-1 of the project is in the final stage, said the company.

Project site offices and residences are being constructed.

The approval has already been given for the acquisition of private land and the use of land in the forest area.

An agreement has been reached with NEA Engineering Company for the construction supervision as consultant of the project. The company will also construct the 18.2 MW Upper Modi Hydroelectric Project.

Pancheshwor project will be forwarded within a month: Minister Saud

RSS
Mahendranagar, Jan. 9

Minister for Foreign Affairs Narayan Prakash Saud has said an understanding has been recently reached between Nepal and India to forward procedural activities of Pancheshwor project within a month.

Sharing the information that minister-level discussion was held about the project during the recent visit of the External Affairs Minister of India, Minister Saud mentioned that decision was taken to forward the activities of the project within a month.

Inaugurating the Municipal-Level President Running Shield Tournament started at Krishnapur municipality of Kanchanpur district from today, he explained that Prime Ministers of both countries also discussed about the project during India visit of Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda'.

"There will be improvement in Nepal's economy while selling the power produced from this project to India", he stressed, adding, employment opportunity would also be created from this grand project.

Saying an agreement was signed to sell 10,000 MW electricity within 10 years, Minister Saud underscored that country's economy could be uplift from agriculture, tourism and power production.

On a different note, he shared that 10 Nepalis lost their lives in Russia-Ukraine war and application has been filed for the rescue of 115 Nepali missing in Russia.

Some Nepali youths joined Russian army force despite government's request not to join the force and some of them lost their lives, he added.

The government has no policy to send Nepalis in risky countries for employment, stated the Foreign Affairs Minister.

Foreign Affairs Minister Saud mentioned that efforts were underway to bring back safely to those who are in Russia, to bring the bodies and to rescue the injured.

Sharing that the government has been continuously taking efforts for the rescue to Bipin Joshi of Kanchanpur, who is said to be under the control of Hamas, he informed that they have got assurance from Qatar for its support in this regard.

'System should be corrected without targeting individuals'

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 9

Minister for Communications and Information Technology, Rekha Sharma, has said any decision to be made disregarding the rights of the Prime Minister, who holds a majority, will not be applicable.

During a meeting of the State Affairs and Good Governance Committee, the House of Representatives in the discussions over the bill to revise the Constitutional Council (Functions, Duties, Powers and Procedures) Act, 2066 (2010) BS, the Government Spokesperson advised to correct the system without focusing on any specific individual.

Responding to concerns raised during discussions on the Bill, Minister Sharma urged participants to work together to strengthen the bill, emphasizing the importance of seeking solutions through consensus without scrutinizing individual characters.

She proposed exploring good practices and alternatives, highlighting that advanced democracy provides viable alternatives to traditional democratic approaches.

The bill's primary focus is on revising the Council's decision-making procedures and quorum requirements. Some members advocated for provisions allowing decisions to be made in the presence of a majority, including the chair.

They argued that Council members should fulfill both constitutional responsibilities and other duties associated with their positions to maintain the integrity of the Council. There was a consensus on ending the trend of some members regularly failing to attend meetings.

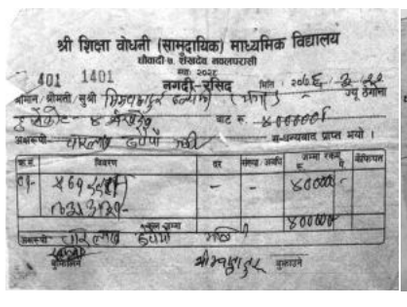
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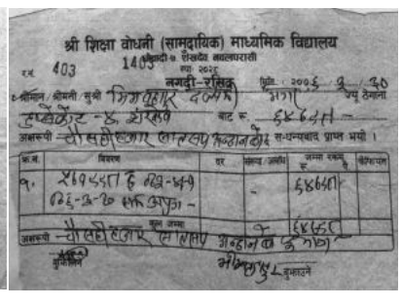
School raises Rs. 464,789 interest from Rs. 40,000 loan

BY BOM LAL GIRI
Nawalpur, Jan. 9

Shree Sikshya Bodhini Community Secondary School in Sankhadev of Hupsekot Rural Municpaity-4, Nawalpur has been found collecting Rs. 464,798 as interest from a loan amount of Rs. 40,000. Additionally, the school had sent notice to the loan taker to pay Rs. 636,796 as interest until July 5, 2023.

More than a decade ago, local Dil Bahadur Rai had taken a loan of Rs. 40,000 from the school and transferred the loan to another local Bel Bahadur Khala. Similarly, Khala transferred the loan to another local Bhim Bahadur Darlami. Since then, Darlami has been paying the interest amounting to approximately half a million.





Darlami said, "A friend of my friend had borrowed Rs. 40,000 at the annual interest rate of 24 per cent. Since, I was in debt to my friend, he transferred the loan of his friend to me. After that, I have already paid Rs. 464,798 in two installments. However, the school sent me a notice stating that I still need to pay Rs. 636,796."

Earlier, the school had sent the notice with the signature of former headmaster Krishna Prasad Neupane.

Padar Bahadur Darlami, son of Darlami, said that the school charged compound interest on the loan.

Former headmaster Neupane said that he had sent notice to Darlami as per the instruction of the school management committee. He further said the committee might have additional information regarding the issue.

While issuing a loan, Mitra Lal Tiwari was the headmaster of the school. When asked about the issue, Tiwari said that he had forgotten about it since it happened a long time ago. "It has already been 7-8 years since I left the school. I don't have an update on the issue," he said.

"At that time, we used to collect money through 'Dhanyanchal' (a process to collect paddy and equivalent cash from people) to pay teachers hired internally. We had invested the money collected from Dhanyanchal in loans to those ready to take it at 24 per cent interest rate."

Mahendra Pandey, Chair of Ward No. 4, said that at that time it was decided to use the money raised by keeping 'Dharmabhakari' (a charity) to run the school. As a result, they started giving loan at 24 per cent interest rate. He said, "It is impossible to speak without seeing the accounts since the transaction was done by the previous committee."

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NEPSE posts double-digit gain, turnover amounts to Rs. 6.11 billion



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 9

The benchmark of the stock market, NEPSE, increased significantly on Tuesday, the third transaction day of the week. The index increased by 20.62 points (1 per cent) to close at 2,080.12 points on Tuesday.

The sensitive index which measures the performance of group 'A' companies increased by 5.64 points to close at 382.92 points. The NEPSE index had posted a growth of 36.57 points on Monday. However, the index declined by 26.36 points on Sunday, first trading day of the week.

A total of 17,949,562 shares worth Rs. 6.11 billion of 309 companies were bought and sold in 104,619 transactions today. The sub-indices of all groups, except hydropower, manufacturing and processing and mutual fund increased in today's transaction.

Sub-index of the development bank group saw the highest growth of 206.05 points followed by hotels and tourism and life-insurance group whose indices increased by 152.28 points and 101.06 points respectively.

Similarly, banking group sub-index increased by 7.79 points, others by 28.94 points, non-life insurance by 67.64 points and finance by 64.46 points. Sub-index trading group increased by26.86 points, microfinance by 40.83 points and investment by 1.01points.

However, the sub-index of hydropower decreased by 11.49 points, manufacturing and processing by 2.47 points and mutual fund by 0.02 points. Share prices of eight companies, including Karnali Development Bank, Sindhu Bikash Bank, Kalika Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha, Saptakoshi Development Bank, Upper Syange Hydropower have increased by 10 per cent.

However, share prices of Dhaulagiri Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha decreased by 8.19 per cent, CEDB Hydropower Development Company by 5.90 per cent and Bindhyabasini Hydropower Development Company by 5.70 per cent.

Tatopani customs succeeds to collect more revenue than target



PHOTO: TRN

Tatopani border point as seen in the picture.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Sindhupalchowk, Jan. 9

Tatopani Customs Office has collected more revenue than the target in the first five months of the current fiscal year. According to Surya Prasad Kafle, customs officer of Tatopani Dry Port Customs Office, 168 per cent revenue of the target has been collected from mid-July to mid-December of the current fiscal year.

In the first five months of the current fiscal year, the Office has collected revenue of Rs. 3.886 billion against a target of Rs. 1.949 billion. The Office has collected around Rs. 616 million in the month of Shrawan, Rs. 768 million in the month of Bhadra, Rs. 1.148 billion in the month of Ashoj, Rs. 752 million in the month of Kartik and Rs. 1.18 billion in the month of Mangsir of the current fiscal year.

He said that due to the import of goods such as apples, pears, garlic, onions, walnuts, ready-made clothes, roll cloths, vehicles, cars, microbuses, scooters, among others, the revenue is being collected in excess of the target.

The handicrafts, mattresses and other items were exported from Nepal to China on September 1, 2023.

He said that no goods were exported to China after that.

Himalaya Airlines becomes Nepal's first IOSA-registered airline



PHOTO: TRN

Airlines Officials seen in a press meet in Kathmandu on Tuesday.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 9

Himalaya Airlines has become Nepal's first and only IOSA-registered airlines operator. The Airlines received IOSA certification from the International Air Transport Association (IATA) on December 28, 2023, with the validity until March 3, 2025, it informed in a statement on Tuesday.

The certificate reads "Himalaya Airlines Pvt. Ltd. has been successfully registered as an IOSA Operator under the IATA Operational Safety Audit Programme (IOSA), by the provisions of the IOSA Programme Manual."

The IOSA certification for Himalaya Airlines confirms that the airlines adheres to the highest safety standards and best practices, providing passengers with a secure and reliable travel experience, claimed the company.

According to it, as the first IOSA-certified airline in Nepal, Himalaya has gained international recognition for its commitment to safety. The rigorous IOSA audit process also evaluates and enhances various aspects of H9's operations, leading to certifiable efficiency, risk management, and overall performance.

Vijay Shrestha, Vice President of the company, this certification not only validates our ongoing efforts to maintain the highest safety standards but also positions us as a trusted airline in the global aviation community.

Likewise, Deputy Director General of the Aviation Safety and Security Regulation Directorate, Nabina Karmacharya, said this accomplishment of Himalaya has helped in reinforcing trust and confidence amongst the passengers, contributing significantly towards the growth and development of air travel in the country.

The IATA-IOSA is a globally recognized and standardized audit programme for airlines which assesses the operational management and control systems of an airline with the primary goal of enhancing operational safety and promoting a common safety standard within the aviation industry.

This process involves an audit of an airline's policies, procedures, and practices. It includes both document reviews and on-site assessments. After the successful completion of the audit and compliance with all findings, IOSA certification is provided to airlines. IOSA registration is thus seen as a mark of safety excellence and is also the prerequisite for IATA membership.

Cooperative staffs arrested for embezzling Rs 1.21 billion of depositors

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 9

Manager and staffs of Kantibhairav Savings and Credit Cooperative Pvt Ltd at Gokarneshowr municipality-8 have been arrested for embezzling savings of depositors. Metropolitan Police Circle, Bouddha, arrested Chairperson of the Cooperative, Hari Krishna Shrestha of Gokarneshwor municipality-4, former Chairperson and patron, Prem Shrestha, Treasurer Sher Lal Shrestha and Joint-Manager Rajendra Shrestha.

All of them have been kept at Gokarna Police Sector building under the Circle, said senior Sub-Inspector at the Sector, Rajesh Karki. Similarly, Manager Ram Das Shrestha, Secretary of Cooperative Board of Directors, members—Anirudra Shrestha and Radheshyam Shrestha as well as coordinator of Account Committee, Chandra Prasad Poudel Shrestha have been absconding. Police have issued arrest warrant in their names. Proprietors of the Cooperative have embezzled Rs 1.21 billion of 7,700 depositors, said chairperson of the taskforce under the Cooperative Victim Struggle Committee, Rajesh Kumar Bista.

Meanwhile, the Central Investigation Bureau (CIB) of Nepal Police has urged alleged victims of fraud perpetrated by the Tinkune-based Real Gorkha Savings and Credit Cooperative Limited to come forward and contact the police.

According to the spokesperson for the Bureau, Nawaraj Adhikari, following the arrest of certain individuals associated with the cooperative, the police require complaints of fraud against the arrestees to initiate legal proceedings. Hence, victims are publicly urged to get in touch with the police promptly and file complaints against the accused.

It has been reported that members of the cooperative's board of directors allegedly misappropriated a substantial amount collected from cooperative members, promising attractive interest rates. The cooperative's services primarily operate in Jorpati and various areas of Bhaktapur, with its central office located in Tinkune, Kathmandu. It has been claimed that a total of Rs 123.5 million from depositors has been misappropriated.

Police have already arrested the cooperative's chair, Harka Bahadur Kathayat, and board member Binod Kumar Ojha in connection with the fraud. These arrests were made following requests for police assistance from the victims.

Boeing 737 Max 9: United Airlines find loose hardware in jet inspections

AP
New York, Jan. 9

Bolts in need of "additional tightening" have been found during inspections of Boeing 737 Max 9s, United Airlines has said. United Airlines said "installation issues" relating to door plugs would be "remedied" before the aircraft type would return to service.

Inspections began after a section of the fuselage fell from an Alaska Airlines 737 Max 9 on Friday. Alaska Airlines says it has since found "some loose hardware" on some Max 9s.

The Federal Aviation Administration (FAA), which regulates air travel in the US, has grounded 171 planes of the same type. United said: "Since we began preliminary inspections on Saturday, we have found instances that appear to relate to installation issues in the door plug - for example, bolts that needed additional tightening."

The door plug is a piece of fuselage, with a window, that fills the space where an emergency exit would be in certain configurations. It was this part of the Alaska Airlines plane which dramatically fell off mid-flight over the US state of Oregon, eventually landing in a teacher's back garden.

The aircraft made an emergency landing but none of the passengers or crew were seriously injured. The plane's door plug was recovered from a teacher's backyard in Oregon and was found without the four bolts, the National Transportation Safety Board said on Monday night.

Its chair Jennifer Homendy told reporters that it's possible the bolts were missing from the start but they may have come off in the descent. The vast majority of Boeing 737 Max 9s used in the US are operated by United Airlines and Alaska, while Turkish Airlines, Panama's Copa Airlines and Aeromexico have also grounded jets of the same model for inspections.

United said it had cancelled 200 flights as of Monday and expected significant cancellations on Tuesday. "We have been able to operate some planned flights by switching to other aircraft types, avoiding about 30 cancellations each on Monday and Tuesday," United added.

Alaska Airlines said that initial reports from technicians preparing its 737 Max 9 fleet for inspection indicated "some loose hardware was visible on some aircraft". "When we are able to proceed with the formal inspection process, all aircraft will be thoroughly inspected in accordance with detailed instructions provided by the FAA in consultation with Boeing," it said.

"Any findings will be fully addressed in a matter that satisfies our safety standards and FAA compliance. The formal inspections will also require documenting all findings and those will be reported to the FAA. No aircraft will be returned to service until all of these steps are complete."

Earlier, the FAA said it had provided a checklist for operators to adhere to during inspections. The FAA said all 737 Max 9 aircraft would remain grounded until operators "complete enhanced inspections which include both left and right cabin door exit plugs, door components, and fasteners".

"Operators must also complete corrective action requirements based on findings from the inspections prior to bringing any aircraft back into service," the statement added. Flight 1282 reached 16,000ft (4.8km) when it began its emergency descent on Friday evening, according to flight tracking data.

Company defrauds people in name of public awareness

BY BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL
Damak, Jan. 9



Damak Municipality has warned a company that allegedly defrauded people in the name of promoting Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) safety.

The municipality received complaints that LP Samyukta Kitchen Gas Centre, based in Khumaltar, Lalitpur Metropolitan City-15, was selling regulators and other items at higher-than-allowed prices. The company had received permission to make Damak denizens aware about LPG use and educate them on best ways to maintain safety. But it supposedly misused that permit to push its own products.

According to Dharma Raj Dahal 'Dipesh', spokesperson for the municipality and chairman of Ward No. 8, LP Samyukta went door-to-door, talked people into buying their regulators at high prices and then charged an addition Rs. 500 to install them.

It is to be further noted that the company is not registered with the local government nor does it have a local dealer authorised to sell its products in Damak.

Dahal informed that the company sold regulators worth Rs. 1,200 in market at Rs. 2,050. "This is outright fraud," he said, adding that the municipality stopped the company from contacting any more people as soon as it learnt of its fraudulent activities. He also said that the customers who had already purchased the regulators were refunded the Rs. 850 that they had initially overpaid.

"The local government has instructed LP Samyukta's representative Benu Kumar Khadka to refund the extra money it charged for its regulators, take back its product from customers who wish to return it and refund the whole amount and not fix a profit margin of more than 20 per cent if it wishes to sell any item in the municipality," Dahal said.

According to the municipality, the company had sold its products to more than 600 people by the time it was stopped.

NEA ANNOUNCES INSTALLMENT FACILITY

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 9

The Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) has announced a five-year installment facility for the payment of electricity tariff dues related to dedicated and trunk line services. In a public notice issued today, the NEA has urged relevant entities to submit applications for installment facilities at the respective NEA distribution centers within the next 30 days.

Following a decision made during the January 1 meeting of the NEA Board of Directors, industries are now eligible for a one-time installment facility to settle their dues associated with dedicated and trunk line services.

The NEA has taken this step in response to the accumulated electricity dues from 61 industries, amounting to Rs 22.24 billion. Consequently, power supply to 24 industries has been disconnected.

COVID sub-variant called JN.1 detected in Nepal

BY PALLAV BHUSAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 9

The Ministry of Health and Population has put forward a notice confirming the presence of new coronavirus sub-variant JN.1 in Nepal. The JN. 1 variant has been found rapidly spreading across various countries in recent weeks.

Issuing a press statement, the Ministry informed that out of 16 samples collected from different parts of the country from various age groups the new sub-variant was confirmed in seven people.

Dr Prakash Budhathoki, the Spokesperson of the Health Ministry, urged the public to exercise precautionary measures after the detection of sub-variant JN. 1. "Even though the new variant is not considered deadly, it is extremely contagious.

It can be fatal to individuals from vulnerable groups especially senior citizens, pregnant women, people suffering from chronic illness, young children and those who haven't taken the vaccine.

Therefore, it is advised that people protect themselves and others by following the COVID-19 safety protocols," he added.

Budhathoki advised the public to wear masks, not to go in crowded places, maintain social distancing and maintain hygiene by washing hands regularly.

The Ministry has also asked all the health desks at the border to screen and observe the movement of the people.

All the health care centres have been urged to get prepared for treatment of patients who get infected with COVID-19.

Similarly, Dr Rudra Prasad Marasini, Director of the Epidemiology and Disease Control Division, informed that the newly discovered sub-variant JN.1 virus is not serious and has the same impact as the previous mutant variants of COVID-19.

"It is transmitted very quickly and easily in masses than the previous variants. However, it does not create complicated health issues apart from some exceptions," he added.

WHO said that based on the current available data the additional public health risk posed by JN.1 is currently evaluated as minimal, but with the onset of winter, JN. 1 could increase the burden of respiratory infections in many countries.

"The JN.1 variant of Coronavirus is not expected to be a serious problem and the existing vaccines will work as long as people take the booster doses. The severity of the illness also depends on a person's immunity and overall health.

Therefore, the public should be aware, but there is no need to panic about the new variant," said Marasini. The new strain was first detected in the United States in September and has spread across the globe rapidly in recent months.

Similarly, the Ministry of Health of Bagmati Province informed on Tuesday that 10 people were found infected with new variant of coronavirus in the last 24 hours in this province.

According to the ministry, in the last 24 hours, 21 people took the COVID-19 test in Bagmati Province out of which 10 results came out positive.

All provincial authorities have been alerted about the new COVID-19 variant and asked to be vigilant and ready for any kind of outbreaks.

Waling locals in panic as they spot leopard

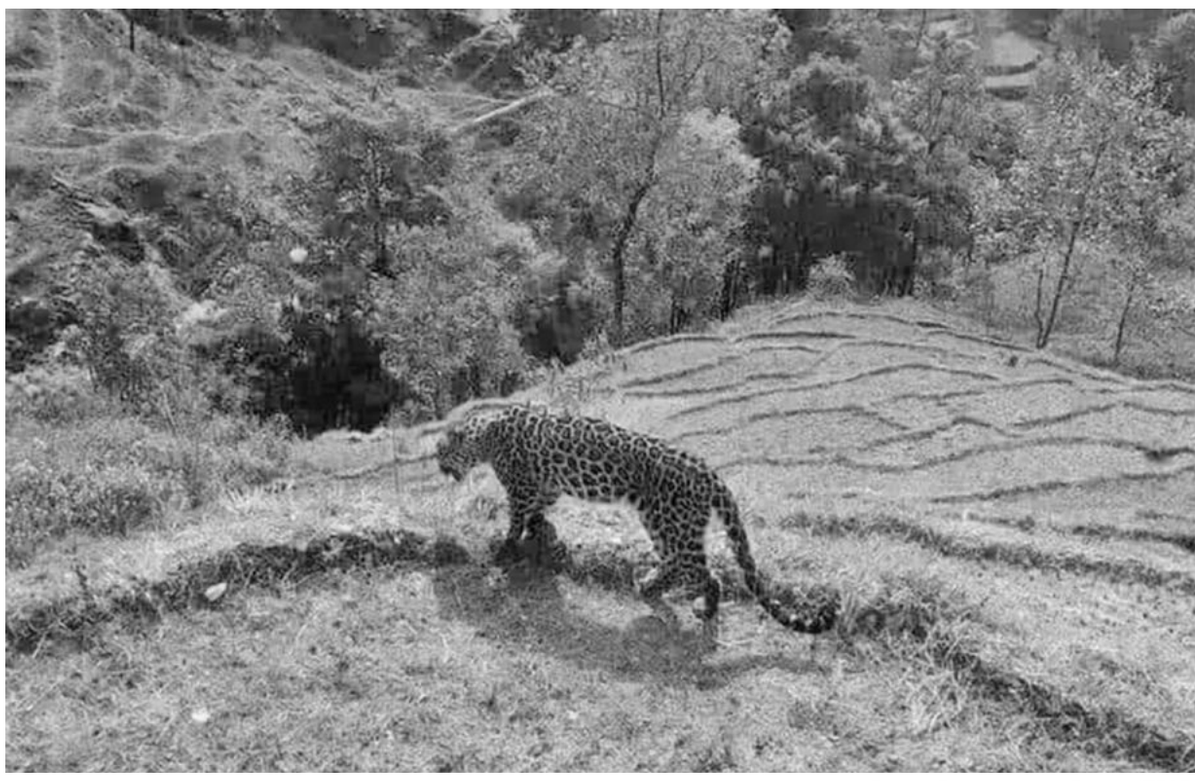


PHOTO: RADHAKRISHNA DUMRE/TRN)

A leopard lurking in the vicinity of Walling in Syangja district.

BY RADHAKRISHNA DUMRE
Waling, Jan. 9

Locals are in panic as a leopard has been spotted roaming in the vicinity of Walling in Syangja district.

Residents of Walling Municipality-12, 13, and 14 are fearful, and are refraining from walking even during the broad daylight.

Bal Prasad Dumre from Waling-13 expressed the challenges faced by students commuting to and from school. He added "Leopards roam around during the day and pose a threat to people. We are struggling to find ways to ensure our safety."

Local Khima Nand Neupane reported that in the previous year, two women and one man were injured in leopard attacks in Ward No. 14 Kafleti.

Bodhraj Kunwar (Raju), Chairman of Ward No. 14, attributed the issue to the proliferation of bushes and unnecessary forests in and around the area. He also urged residents to clear any unnecessary bushes around their houses to address the problem.

Rare bird species spotted in Narayani River

BY MEENA KANDEL
Kawasoti, Jan. 9

Baikal teal (Sibirionetta Formosa), also called the bimaculate duck or squawk duck, is a beautiful small duck native to eastern Siberia, but it was recently spotted in and around the Narayani River in Nepal's Nawalpur district.

Baikal teal, one of the very rare species for Nepal and is listed as a vagrant species in "Birds of Nepal" was spotted during a monitoring visit to the river on Sunday.

DB Chowdhury, the Chitwan West Sector Coordinator of the Winter Water Bird Census, said that Nepal is currently hosting extremely rare migratory birds along the Narayani River in Kawasoti-13.

Baikal teal general migrates to east Asia to escape winter and find food.

Birds from various countries have arrived in and around the Narayani River in eastern Nawalparasi to spend the winter, he added.

Baikal teal, the winter migratory bird has been recorded in Kathmandu, Pokhara, and Chitwan for a long time, but this rare bird has been spotted in Nawalpur for the first time, Chaudhary informed.

Nepal serves as a winter habitat for numerous migratory bird species. Baikal Teals generally visit the country during the winter months, and it has made its first visit to the Narayani River in Nawalpur this year, Chaudhary said.

Various types of birds, including indigenous, winter migratory, and summer migratory species, can be found in the vicinity of the Narayani River. Particularly the water birds migrate to this area during this month.

According to Chaudhary, birds from Siberia, China, Burma, Mongolia, Russia, Korea, Thailand, and other countries are currently visiting this area.

Among the birds that visit the area, there are birds of different species including ducks and Great cormorants.



PHOTO COURTESY: MEENA KANDEL

Migratory bird called Baikal teal (Sibirionetta Formosa), also called the bimaculate duck or squawk duck, is spotted in Narayani River in Nawalpur district.

Nature guide, Maan Bahadur Choudhary said that the migratory birds visit the area from September to December and begin their return to their native habitats in February after the temperature starts to rise.

Given the presence of various bird species in Nepal during the winter season, a winter water bird census has been conducted. The water bird census started across the country on January 6 and the count will start in and around the Kawasoti area the Narayani River in a few days.

Water supply from Melamchi to resume soon

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 9

The repair work on the Melamchi Drinking Water Project has reached its final stage. The much-awaited Melamchi Project, initially designed to satisfy the water needs of the people in Kathmandu, suffered extensive damage from a devastating flood in June 2021, just a few months after the water supply to the Valley.

It is set to resume operation in a few weeks, staying within the stipulated time frame, said Senior Divisional Engineer of the Project, Padam Bahadur Kunwar. "We plan to release water from the estuary area within a week, but it may take some additional time to ensure water reaches every household in Kathmandu," he added.

He said that 80 per cent of the repair work in the estuary area of the project has been completed so far. "In total, 95 per cent of the machine work and 80 per cent of the human work has been accomplished. We are currently engaged in cleaning the galvanized iron (GI) pipes inside the tunnels and clearing debris from the Number 9 gate," Kunwar added. There are many gates but only Gate No. 1, 9, 21 and 38 are in use right now, he informed.

Meanwhile, on Wednesday, a delegation of stakeholders made an on-site inspection about the work being done at the source of the Melamchi Water Supply Project at Helambu Municipality-1.

Earlier, on December 19, Ministry of Water Supply and the contractor company Sino Hydro signed a memorandum of understanding to facilitate the supply of Melamchi water to the Valley within next 28 days.

The meeting, chaired by Secretary at the Ministry Suresh Acharya, resolved to ensure the supply of Melamchi water to every household in Kathmandu within the specified timeframe, provided there was no emergency. The agreement was also made to mobilise resources immediately for the construction and clearance work. The work is going on as per the agreement, Kunwar added.

The water will be processed by Kathmandu Upatyaka Khanepani Limited (KUKL) at Sundarijal Water Treatment Plant and redistributed to households in Kathmandu Valley. The Melamchi water supply was halted due to monsoon rains on June 23, 2023.

The devastating floods on June 15 and July 31, 2021, swept away the Melamchi water project built over almost two decades to quench the thirst of the people in Kathmandu Valley.

The flood also swept away land, houses, schools, and industries in Melamchi Municipality, Helambu Rural Municipality, Panchpokhari Thangpal Rural Municipality, and Indrawati Rural Municipality.

Initiated in 1998 by the Melamchi Water Supply Development Board, the project was meant to be completed by 2006. Multiple deadline extensions followed, but the headworks remain buried under over 12 metres of debris left by the flash flood in 2021.

NEWS BRIEF

Father kills son in Ilam

Ilam: Police have arrested 36-year-old Dil Kumar Rai, a resident of Mai Municipality-6 Bihibare, on the charge of murdering his 19-year-old son Jivan Rai.

Jivan Rai, who was seriously injured in a minor household dispute on Monday night, died during treatment at B&C Hospital in Birtamode, according to a news bulletin issued by the Nepal Police Headquarters on Tuesday.

As soon as the information about the incident was received, the police stationed at Mahamai police station arrested father Dil Kumar. Further investigation in the case is undergoing, said police.

47 kg silver ornaments seized

Kathmandu: Police have seized 47 kilograms of illegal silver ornaments from Kathmandu-21, Bhotebahal, Koteshwar and other places of the Kathmandu Valley.

In the operation, police have also arrested three alleged smugglers on the charge of possessing the silver on Monday evening.

Among those arrested include - 50-year-old Kameshwar Sah of Kalaiya Municipality-10, Bara, 32-year-old Suman Kumar Sararf of Birgunj Metropolitan Municipality-3, Parsa and 20-year-old Manish Sararf of Bishrampur Rural Municipality-5, Bara.

Based on the information that the silver jewellery was being stored and sold without receipt of bills in Bhotebhal, Koteshwar and other places, the police deputed from Kathmandu Valley Crime Investigation Office, Min Bhawan, arrested them during the investigation.

They have been sent to the Department of Revenue Investigation, Harihar Bhawan, Lalitpur for further investigation and action on the offence of revenue evasion.

Man arrested for possessing handgun

Kaski: Police arrested 69-year-old Yambir Garbuja, resident of Myagdi Annapurna Rural Municipality-6, from Pokhara Metropolitan City-3 Nadipur area, along with a weapon that looked like a small handgun, on Monday afternoon.

The police deputed from the District Police Office, Kaski found the weapon and arrested him while conducting a raid at Garbuja's house on Monday.

The police are conducting necessary investigations in this regard.

(TRN)

Breastfeeding room set up at Pashupatinath Temple premises

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan 9

A breast-feeding room has been set up on the premises of Pashupatinath Temple.

Minister of State for Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, Sushila Sirpali Thakuri, inaugurated the breastfeeding room today.

The facility, established by the Pashupati Area Development Trust (PADT), has come into operation from today.

On the occasion, Minister of State Thakuri appreciated the establishment of the facility facilitating breastfeeding in a hygienic environment.

She said operation of the breastfeeding room in the Pashupatinath Temple precincts will give a positive message to devotees coming from within the county and abroad.

PADT executive director Laxmi Pun said that breastfeeding mothers visiting the Temple with their infant children have now been freed of the compulsion of breastfeeding their child on the pavement, the office of security personnel and outdoors for lack of breastfeeding room.

MINISTER RAI DIRECTS KU TO LIFT SUSPENSION OF DR. DAHAL

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan 9

Minister for Education, Science and Technology, Ashok Kumar Rai, has directed the Kathmandu University to immediately remove the suspension of a residential doctor Dr Bishad Dahal of Kathmandu Medical College. Minister issued this directive as the pro-chancellor of Kathmandu University.

Informing that Education, Health and Information Technology Committee under the House of Representatives today about the Minister Rai's directives, Secretary at the Education Ministry, Suresh Adhikari, said directive was issued to mobilize doctors in health camp only after issuance of criteria determined by KU after lifting the suspension of Dahal. The KMC had suspended Dr Dahal citing non-participation in the health camp but voices were raised in the Parliamentary Committee saying the action was not in accordance with law.

DPM Khadka stresses on making astrology accessible to all

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan 9

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Defence Purna Bahadur Khadka has said it is necessary to expand the reach of astrological knowledge to all.

Inaugurating the Silver Jubilee Programme of Nepal Astrologers Council here today, he stressed on making the traditional astrology accessible to all through the new technology.

"It is necessary to make the astrology more advanced. The government will provide necessary support for its advancement," he said, adding that astrology should not be practiced irresponsibly and misused.

He suggested making definite work procedures and standards for astrology studies. World Astrology Federation president Dr Lok Raj Poudel called on the government to make arrangements for providing license to the astrologers. He shared that more than 14 thousand astrologers throughout the country are the members of the Council.

Founded in 2053 BS, the Council has expanded its branches in all the 77 districts, seven provinces and in the Kathmandu Valley. Council president Madhav Raj Pandey said the National Astrology Day will be celebrated in second week of April 2025. The Council also felicitated various personalities making significant contribution to its development.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

He is richest who is content with the least, for content is the wealth of nature.
- Socrates

EDITORIAL

New COVID-19 Variant

The emergence of the JN.1 variant of COVID-19 in Nepal acts as a reminder that nations worldwide are continuously struggling to combat against the virus. The occurrence of new variant, which has been seen in India and China as well, requires increased focus to address the situation. Recognition by the Ministry of Health and Population (MoHP) in recent weeks to validate its presence as supported by genomic sequencing at the National Public Health Laboratory presents a worrying reality. MoHP calls for a need to screen people at border entry points more than ever. For those vaccinated against COVID-19, JN. 1 does not seem to manifest such harsh effects on sufferers of the disease.

However, the unvaccinated and those with underlying health issues should be careful. This also emphasises the need for vaccination and continuing public health-related measures. The efforts of the MoHP to implement health standards should be praised. Once again, MoHP pleads people to follow protocols: do not go in crowded areas, keep distance between people, wear masks, and wash hands frequently. There is still a need for such measures to help in the containment of transmission, despite what the variant may be. Despite these recommendations, many have relaxed their precautions, making it challenging to convince them to reinstate these safety measures.

The World Health Organisation (WHO) has already launched a global alert, noting the growing danger that the JN.1 variant poses with this year's increase in influenza cases. This emphasises the need for a collective global effort to fight the challenges. Even though WHO announced the end of a pandemic era, it is important to be vigilant. Appropriate and timely testing can help spot the disease early, isolating it from others before it spreads across society's groups during such seasons when respiratory illnesses or fevers are prevalent. The identification of the JN.1 variant urges reconsideration of the strategies that were in use earlier to overcome such epidemics. The border regions are very vulnerable to the virus, as many Nepali citizens returning from India have been found positive for COVID-19.

The fact that antigen testing is obligatory at Nepal-India border points should be appreciated, but it has to undergo a reliable method for detecting the new strains of virus. With hundreds of Nepali nationals returning each day from across the border, community transmission looms as a major concern. To achieve adherence to COVID-19 protocols, returnees and local communities need to collaborate. Some of the checkpoints do not have any confirmed virus cases. Therefore, it is important that a proper, comprehensive, and consistent approach to testing as well as monitoring would be carried out.

In order to address the problems encountered by health checkpoints at the border, such as logistics and socio-economic aspects, a quick approach is needed. The control measures are effective if they have adequate resources, training, and support for health care professionals at checkpoints. Implementing mandatory antigen testing is an excellent initiative. However, it has to be combined with a good reporting system and cooperation between bordering countries. As the public health sector adjusts to challenges, coordinated efforts against the virus will be most effective.

Winter Care

DIXYA POUDEL

The world is in the midst of winter season in the Northern hemisphere. Everyone seems to be aggrieved by the cold. Even with the warmest of clothes, it is still cold. And the coldness in the air seems to sting every time one is outdoors. On better days, the sun shines and for a minute it feels warm and pleasant, only for the chill to return during the evenings and early in the mornings. One can't regulate the whim of the cold which the nature decrees, but there are measures that one can observe in order to overcome winter grievances.

One has to be especially particular about skin and hair care during the winter. Skin tends to be dry and flaky in winter while hair seems to be dull and brittle. This is because in winter, the air is drier, colder and lacks moisture. This decreases the skin's natural moisture in its lipid barriers which is a protective layer of skin. Skin thus tends to be flaky, scaly and raw with cracks, redness, itchiness and a rough texture. As such, the water content of the epidermis on skin tends to reflect the humidity level in the environment. Similarly, the dry and cold air happens to strip the moisture away from the strands and pores of hair which is why it is rough, brittle and dry in the colder season.

To fight the pesky dryness on skin, make sure to moisturise your face and body generously. It is even better to switch to a cream-based moisturiser in case you have an extra dry skin. Likewise, cleanse your face with a mild face-wash and don't forget to apply sunscreen, even if you are staying indoors. It is recommended to use sunscreen daily and apply the right kind of sunscreen that suits your skin type. Especially, lips tend to get chapped in winter which is why you should invest in a moisturising lip balm or chapstick, preferably with an SPF of at least 15. Further, keep your makeup to a minimum and use hydrating cosmetics.

When it comes to hair, limit your shampoo use and don't forget to condition your hair, especially at the ends. Hair masks are also recommended during winter. Anti-frizz serums too help manage dry and damaged hair. If possible cover your hair with a scarf whenever you head outdoors. Likewise, limit the use of heat appliances such as dryers, curlers and straighteners.

Further, make sure you moisturise your hands often, each time you wash them or when you have done the dishes (hands tend to get drier since they are exposed to the air often). As such, care for your nails as well which can be brittle in the cold.

These are some advices to care for your skin and hair. But don't overlook the importance of diet, nutrition and exercise during winter. Take healthy amounts of foods such as anti-oxidant rich superfoods like beetroots, nuts, seeds, mushrooms, green leafy vegetables, citrus fruits, etc. Exercise too is crucial to balance the metabolism of the body. Movement and stretching can help to keep warm with a boost in blood circulation.

Deep in the winter, the cold might be quite a grievance but it can be manageable with these suggestions which might even make winter adaptable and agreeable.

An Ideally Assertive Editor

Dhruba Adhikary



Gokul Prasad Pokhrel, who passed away on January 1st, was chief editor of the Gorakhapatra daily when Nepal was preparing for its first (and till date last) referendum which was to decide the political system suited for the country—by retaining existing partyless Panchayat system 'with suitable reforms', or opting for a multiparty structure similar to the ones practiced in India and the United Kingdom. King Birendra had announced the referendum, responding to the student agitation witnessed in early months of 1979. It was around that time I was recruited as a sub-editor for the Nepali language daily. And Pokhrel was the first editor I met. Bharat Koirala, Gorakhapatra Sansthan's chairman-cum-general manager, also introduced me to the Rising Nepal editor, Mana Ranjan Josse (MRJ).

Together with Koirala, who already had a stint as the editor of Gorakhapatra, Pokhrel and Josse formed a troika—known for their assertiveness. Their views were patiently listened to by the senior royal palace officials who obviously were in regular contact with the king. Needless to emphasise, the king in that era wielded considerable authority in the state affairs. And every now and then, state functionaries, located at Singha Durbar to formally govern the country, invited ('summoned' would not be the right word) the troika for consultations on emerging national issues. Campaign period leading to the referendum voting (2nd May 1980) lasted for about ten months. While newspapers in the private sector (there were no privately-run radio networks) enjoyed unfettered freedom to write about the boons of the multiparty system, the official media outlets, however, quickly began to feel the euphoric start would not last long.

Slowly, high-placed officials found it expedient to unofficially advise the official media heads to be supportive to the partyless campaigners. The minister holding information portfolio at the time purportedly urged the troika to be sympathetic to the status quoists. But since ministerial persuasiveness appeared at variance with the monarch's desire to genuinely understand public perception of—and commitment to—democracy in the kingdom, Koirala, Pokhrel and Josse expressed their disagreement instantly. They were even ostensibly prepared to quit their posts, an action that would have been a huge embarrassment to the transitional government.

Gentle & unassuming

MRJ remembers, through a social media post, his friend and colleague Pokhrel as the "most gentle and unassuming journalist." And in his view, Pokhrel belonged to "modern Nepal's first generation of newsmen." This statement contains an eloquent tribute to a person with whom he had an enviable camaraderie. And, as MRJ has further noted, Pokhrel wore many hats including that of founder and chair of Nepal Press Institute (NPI).

Now a couple of points about NPI. This institution was founded in 1984 and I happened to be in the core team that initially ran NPI's flagship training programme (10-month course) for men and women aspiring to be journalists. My association with Pokhrel which began at Gorakhapatra continued for several years through NPI. Many of us today can fathom how much relentless efforts were required to convince the authorities under Panchayat dispensation about the usefulness of such an entity for a forward-looking society. Fortunately, persuasive Pokhrel received active support for this pursuit from several journalists including influential Bharat Koirala and seasoned editor Gopal Dass Shrestha of 'The Commoner', the kingdom's first English language daily. Shrestha represented the private sector where news outlets were freer to report events and offer independent views on contemporary issues.

> Pokhrel's commitment to a free press always remained steadfast and discernible. He knew free press was feasible only in a democratic environment.

Incidentally, there is a separate story on how the NPI project got expedited. Ironically, it came in the form of an unpleasant incident: Pokhrel was once suspended from the editor's duty, in the 1980s. It was related to a timeless news report on the country's national museum and its prized possessions. Those included guns and military equipment that Nepali soldiers had snatched from their foes during Nepal's war with Tibet (circa AD 1788).There was nothing wrong about the reportage itself, but the timing of its publication was not considered right : the story got into print literally on the eve of an official visit to Nepal by China's president Li Xiannian.

Incredibly true

In the opinion of palace officials, it was a deliberate act and amounted to great awkwardness; hence they insisted for an instant 'action'. Although it was his colleagues at the reporting unit directly responsible, editor Pokhrel took the moral responsibility, and agreed to be suspended in order to facilitate an investigation. Incredible but true, Pokhrel refused to be disheartened. On the contrary, he utilised that 'free time' to push through his dream project. He rightly argued that journalism skills need to be imparted to the emerging generation who would eventually cater to the needs of the expanding media sector. This was how NPI was born, in 1984. Anyway, the suspension notifications issued to him and three other journalists were rescinded afterwards. As is clear, that particular unforeseen incident turned out to be a silver-lining as far as NPI is concerned.

Pokhrel's commitment to a free press always remained steadfast and discernible. He knew free press was feasible only in a democratic environment. And he would not hesitate to express his belief whenever necessary although he was perceived to be the least vocal member of the troika. One striking example of this occurred in July 1982. When BP Koirala passed away the king's press secretary summoned the heads of official media organisations to the palace to discuss the quantity and quality of the coverage it deserved, the troika from Gorakhapatra Sansthan openly hesitated to demonise the works Koirala had done as prime minister (1959-60), and the political role he played afterwards. Pokharel's interview to Naresh Fuyal of Baarakhari online, published on 29th December 2018, contains some of the relevant information pertaining to the palace discussion at that time.

As far as I recall, upon return from the palace meeting, Pokhrel promptly put pen to paper and produced an editorial to be printed in the next day's newspaper. The editorial comment visibly hailed Koirala's contributions for the country. To the intelligentsia of that time, it was a remarkable stand coming out from the newspaper traditionally recognised as official. As a junior colleague in Pokhrel's editorial team, I was close enough to learn about the assertiveness of my boss and other members of the troika. Their works and bold stand continue to be a source of inspiration.

(Adhikary is a journalist active since 1978 and writes on regional issues. dhrubahari@gmail.com)

Sheikh Hasina: Longest Serving Female Prime Minister

Namrata Sharma



Sheikh Hasina Wazed and her party the Awami League (AL) has won the national elections of Bangladesh for the fourth consecutive term in office as Prime Minister. This has made her the longest serving female head of government in the world and the longest serving Bangladeshi Prime Minister. She has been in this post since 2009. This is the fifth victory for the AL. The main opposition party of Bangladesh, the Bangladesh National Party (BNP) headed by Khalida Zia, boycotted the elections and created a void in the country for a strong opposition to contest Hasina. Both Hasina and Zia had actually joined hands against the autocratic regime of Hussain Muhammad Ershad and were key in bringing that regime to an end. Since then, there has been a tussle between these two leaders of Bangladesh with their parties AL and BNP opposing each other.

Low turnout

Now among accusation of curtailing the freedom of speech and involvement in undemocratic practices by the citizens of Bangladesh, Hasina has emerged to be a powerful leader of one of the most densely populated countries in the world. According to the Election Commissioner of Bangladesh, the voter turnout was very low. Only 40 per cent voters of the eligible 120 million eligible voters turned out to cast their votes. Bangladesh has a population of 170 million people.

Sheikh Hasina is the daughter of the founding father and first Prime Minister of Bangladesh, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman. On August 15, 1975 after about four years of having led Bangladesh to independence from Pakistan, Mujibur Rahman was assassinated along with a majority of his family. Sheikh Hasina escaped this assassination as she had gone to meet her husband, who was a Bangladeshi physicist, writer and chairman of the Bangladesh Atomic Energy Commission, in Germany. After that she was in exile in India for a period of six years where she lived by hiding her identity.

Later, as leader of the opposition on August 21, 2004 a grenade attack on the Awami League gathering in Dhaka killed 24 senior AL party members. Sheikh Hasina narrowly escaped that attack which was mainly targeted to kill her. In several similar assassination attempts Hasina has lost several friends and family members. She has survived a total of 19 assassination attempts on her life. After the grenade attack of 2004 she suffers from hearing impairment.

India has always been an ally of PM Hasina. During her 19 years of premiership, she has been successful in improving Bangladesh's economy and promoting development activities in the country. However, the West, mainly the USA, is very critical of the democracy in Bangladesh. There are several accusations against the AL government that under the leadership of Hasina democracy has been slowly silenced. Anyone who speaks against her or her government faces jail terms.

Mahfuz Anam, Editor of The Daily Star News of Bangladesh, says that the administration of Sheikh Hasina's government is very repressive in an interview by Jyoti Malhotra, Founding Editor of AwazSouthAsia. Anam, a senior Editor of Bangladesh, stated that BNP boycotted the results which gave space for the overall grounds for Hasina to win her fourth straight win and fifth power as prime minister. He says that not contesting in elections is "like committing suicide", therefore the BNP, in his opinion, should have contested the election, no matter how repressive Hasina's government was.

> During the long rule of Hasina and AL she is given credit to having led Bangladesh out of poverty.

During the long rule of Hasina and AL she is given credit to having led Bangladesh out of poverty. But at the same time, she is known to be slowly curtailing the freedom of the people who raised a different voice. The digital security Act she brought in 2018 has been under severe criticism within Bangladesh and internationally. This Act gives the government authority to control the internet or any media by imprisonment of various terms and curtail the freedom of the press. In 2022 the Hasina government ordered the closure of 191 websites accusing them of releasing "anti-state news" citing intelligence reports.

There are several news reports that have come out from Bangladesh and internationally, particularly from the western world, that Hasina has resorted to using unethical practices in garnering votes on her side. The low voter turn-out implies that the majority of the Bangladeshis were not keen on voting for AL. During Sunday's general elections, according to the Reuters news agency, polling booths were set ablaze on the eve of the vote, with four people including two children killed in a train fire. The US Government has openly criticised that Bangladesh has not held a free and fair election.

Economic growth

However, Bangladesh and Sheikh Hasina's government has received continuous support from India. There is a general feeling that Hasina has taken pro-active steps towards development and economic growth of her country. Several people have opined that as she is repressing a critical voice against her government, there is a high chance that the country will slowly slip into debt traps and retrogressive economic growth. The other question that people ask is: If her policies are supporting development and she is emerging as a very strong, dynamic and powerful leader, why is she resorting to regressive and anti-democratic practices like curtailing the freedom of press and speech?

Editor Mahfuz Anam, in his interview to AawazSouthAsia, said that the fear of having lost several family members and friends to assassinations, and facing a series of assassination attempts might have inspired her to develop a strategy to curtail future assassination attempts on her by introducing stringent rules and regulations which are contrary to democratic norms and values.

(Namrata Sharma is a senior journalist and women rights advocate and can be reached at namrata1964@yahoo.com X handle: @NamrataSharmaP)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 10, 1974

Oil Corporation To Receive Much Fuel Soon

Kathmandu, Jan. 9: Royal Nepal Airlines Corporation and the Thai International can in the near future operate as many flights as they used to, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

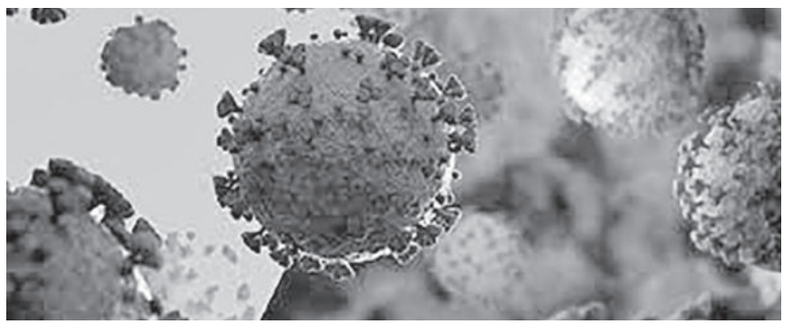
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READER'S MAIL

Stay Safe From Coronavirus



I am writing this letter with regard to the news *'Coronavirus detected among India-returnees'* published in the front page of your esteemed newspaper on Tuesday. As per the news, coronavirus infection has been detected among Nepali nationals returning from different Indian cities. This is a cause for concern as those infected could be carrying the new JN.1 variant of the SARS-CoV-2 virus.

The authorities should ramp up testing and the people must begin adopting precautions again. The Ministry of Health and Population has already issued an advisory to mask up and maintain social distancing when in crowded places. We should follow this to prevent a full-blown outbreak on the scale of what we saw in 2020 and 2021.

Nevertheless, the government should begin preparing for the worst and at least make plans to care for the children, senior citizens and those with compromised immunity. As the old adage goes, "Hope for the best but prepare for the worst."

Pankaj Kafle
Kirtipur

TAILPIECE

A family took their frail, elderly mother to a nursing home and left her, hoping she would be well cared for. The next morning, the nurses bathed her, fed her a tasty breakfast, and set her in a chair at a window overlooking a lovely flower garden.

She seemed okay, but after a while she slowly started to tilt sideways in her chair. Two attentive nurses immediately rushed up to catch her and straighten her up.

Again she seemed okay, but after a while she slowly started to tilt over to her other side. The nurses rushed back and once more brought her back upright. This went on all morning. Later, the family arrived to see how the old woman was adjusting to her new home.

"So Ma, how is it here? Are they treating you all right?"

"It's pretty nice," she replied. "Except they won't let me fart."

Blinken looks to planning for post-war Gaza

AP
Israel, Jan. 9

U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken faced tough talks with Israeli leaders on Gaza's post-war future Tuesday, while Israel's military pushed ahead with its offensive in the beleaguered territory. Heavy bombardment and fighting shook refugee camps, sending Palestinians scrambling to find safety and hampering aid groups' efforts to get relief to the population.

Blinken said he was coming to Israel with promises from four Arab nations and Turkey to help in rebuilding Gaza after the war. But those nations also want to see an end to the fighting in Gaza and concrete steps toward the eventual creation of a Palestinian state alongside Israel, something Israel Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has vowed not to allow.

The U.S. and Israel also remain deeply divided over how Gaza will be run when — and if — its current Hamas rulers are defeated. American officials have called for the Palestinian Authority, which currently governs parts of the Israeli-occupied West Bank, to take the reins in Gaza. Israeli leaders have rejected that idea but haven't put forward a concrete plan beyond an open-ended military control over the territory.

At the same time, Blinken is trying to prevent an all-out war between Israel and Lebanon's Hezbollah. After a presumed Israeli strike last week hit Beirut, killing Hamas's deputy leader, the two sides have stepped up their exchanges. On Tuesday, Hezbollah said its exploding drones targeted the Israeli army northern command in the town of Safed — deeper into Israel than previous fire by the group. The Israeli military said a drone fell at a base in the north without causing damage, suggesting it had been intercepted. It did not identify the base. "There is lots to talk about, in particular about the way forward," Blinken said after meeting Israeli President Isaac Herzog.



PHOTO: AP

U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken, centre, walks on the day of meetings with Israeli ministers in Tel Aviv, Israel, Tuesday, Jan. 9, 2024.

The United States has pressed Israel to scale down its offensive in Gaza to more precise operations targeting Hamas. But the pace of death and destruction has remained largely the same, with several hundred Palestinians killed a day, according to health officials in Gaza. Israel has vowed to keep going until it has destroyed Hamas throughout the territory, in response to the Oct. 7 attack during which militants killed some 1,200 people, mainly civilians, in southern Israel and kidnapped around 250 others. Still, after three months of fighting, Hamas continues to put up a fierce fight.

The Israeli military says it has dismantled Hamas infrastructure in northern Gaza, where large swaths of the cityscape have been demolished. But fighting continues there against what Israel says are pockets of militants.

The offensive's focus has shifted to the southern city of Khan Younis, where ground troops have been fighting militants for weeks, and a number of urban refugee camps in central Gaza.

"The fighting will continue throughout 2024," military spokesman Daniel Hagari said.

Since the war began, Israel's assault in Gaza has killed more than 23,200 Palestinians, about two-thirds of them women and children, and more than 58,000 have been wounded, according to the Health Ministry in Hamas-run Gaza. The death toll does not distinguish between combatants and civilians. Nearly 85% of Gaza's population of 2.3 million have been driven from their homes by the fighting, and a quarter of its residents face starvation, with only a trickle of food, water, medicine and other supplies entering through an Israeli siege.

Throughout the night and into Tuesday morning, warplanes struck multiple areas in and around Khan Younis. Israeli artillery shelling and gunfire echoed through the Nuseirat refugee camp in central Gaza, where troops have been pushing in from the north, said one resident, Saeed Moustafa. They were facing heavy resistance from gunmen in the camp, he said.

Like other refugee camps in Gaza, Nuseirat was built to house Palestinians driven out of homes during the 1948 war surrounding Israel's creation, and over the decades it has been built up into a densely populated town housing refugees and their descendants.

Families in Nuseirat's northern neighborhoods were fleeing to other parts of the camp, Moustafa said by phone, with the sound of sporadic gunfire in the background. Some tried to head south on the Gaza's main north-south road but found it blocked by Israeli tanks and turned around, he said.

Macron names Attal as France's prime minister

AFP
France, Jan. 9

President Emmanuel Macron on Tuesday named education minister Gabriel Attal as prime minister in a bid to give new momentum to his presidency, with the 34-year-old becoming France's youngest and first openly gay head of government, a source close to the presidency told AFP.

After days of intense behind-the-scenes manoeuvring, outgoing prime minister Élisabeth Borne resigned Monday evening, with Attal emerging as the favourite to succeed the 62-year-old.

The absence of a swift announcement fuelled talk that heavyweight government figures might be involved in intense bargaining over Attal.

However sources close to those said to be behind the tensions, including Interior Minister Gérard Darmanin and Finance Minister Bruno Le Maire, vehemently denied this.

The reshuffle comes ahead of the Olympic Games in Paris and European parliament elections this summer where Macron's centrist forces risk defeat at the hands of the far-right under Marine Le Pen.

Commentators see the reshuffle as essential to relaunch Macron's centrist presidency for its last three years and prevent him becoming a "lame duck" leader after a series of crises.

Since he defeated the far right to win a second term in 2022, Macron has faced protests over unpopular pension reforms, the loss of his overall majority in parliamentary elections and controversy over immigration legislation.



PHOTO: AFP

Gabriel Attal (left) pictured with French President Emmanuel Macron on September 1, 2023.

While Macron cannot run again in 2027 presidential elections, relaunching his government is seen as crucial to help prevent Le Pen becoming president.

Other possible candidates to succeed Borne included 37-year-old Defence Minister Sébastien Lecornu and 43-year-old Julien Denormandie, a former agriculture minister.

The conservative daily Le Figaro said Borne was leaving a political situation "that remains as fragile as ever".

"Changing a face at the top doesn't change the overall picture," the newspaper said, adding Borne's successor was facing "an overwhelming pile of political emergencies" including the task to unite a fragmented nation.

Moon landing attempt fails

AP
Cape Canaveral, Fla., Jan. 9

The first U.S. moon landing attempt in more than 50 years appeared to be doomed after a private company's spacecraft developed a "critical" fuel leak just hours after Monday's launch.

Pittsburgh-based Astrobotic Technology managed to orient its lander toward the sun so the solar panel could collect sunlight and charge its battery, as a special team assessed the status of what was termed "a failure in the propulsion system."

It soon became apparent, however, that there was "a critical loss of fuel," further dimming hope for what had been a planned moon landing on Feb. 23.

Late Monday, the company said the leak was continuing and estimated that the lander would start losing solar power in about 40 hours.

The trouble was reported about seven hours after Monday's predawn liftoff from Cape Canaveral Space Force Station. United Launch Alliance's Vulcan rocket provided the lift for Astrobotic's lander, named Peregrine, putting it on a long, roundabout path to the moon.

A propulsion system problem "threatens the ability of the spacecraft to soft land on the moon," the company said. The lander is equipped with engines and thrusters for maneuvering, not only during the cruise to the moon but for lunar descent.

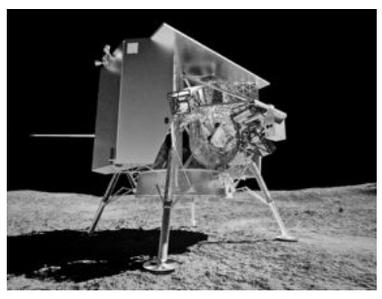


PHOTO: AP

This illustration provided by Astrobotic Technology in 2024 depicts the Peregrine lunar lander on the surface of the moon.

Astrobotic released a photo from a lander-mounted camera, which the company said showed a "disturbance" in a section of thermal insulation. That aligns with what is known so far of the problem, the company said.

Astrobotic was aiming to be the first private business to successfully land on the moon, something only four countries have accomplished.

A second lander from a Houston company is due to launch next month. NASA gave the two companies millions to build and fly their own lunar landers.

SKorea's parliament bans production, sales of dog meat

AP
South Korea, Jan. 9

South Korea's parliament on Tuesday passed a landmark ban on production and sales of dog meat, as public calls for a prohibition have grown sharply over concerns about animal rights and the country's international image.

Some angry dog farmers said they plan to challenge the bill's constitutionality and hold protest rallies, a sign of continued heated debate over the ban.

After a three-year grace period, the bill would make slaughtering, breeding and sales of dog meat for human consumption illegal from 2027 and punishable by 2-3 years in prison. It doesn't provide any penalties for eating dog meat.

Dog meat consumption, a centuries-old practice on the Korean Peninsula, is neither explicitly banned nor legalized in South Korea. It has long been viewed as a source of stamina on hot summer days. Recent surveys show more than half of South Koreans want dog meat banned and a majority no longer eat it. But one in every three South Koreans still opposes a ban even though they don't consume it.

The National Assembly passed the bill by a 208-0 vote. It will become law after being endorsed by the Cabinet Council and signed by President Yoon Suk Yeol, considered formalities since his government supports the ban.

"This law is aimed at contributing to realizing the values of animal rights, which pursue respect for life and a harmonious co-existence between humans and animals," the legislation says.

The bill offers assistance to dog farmers and others in the industry in shutting down their businesses and shifting to alternatives. Details are to be worked out among government officials, farmers, experts and animal rights activists.

Dozens of animal rights activists gathered at the National Assembly to celebrate the bill's passage. They carried large photos of dogs, chanted slogans and held placards reading "Dog meat-free Korea is coming."

Humane Society International called the legislation's passage "history in the making."

"I never thought I would see in my lifetime a ban on the cruel dog meat industry in South Korea, but this historic win for animals is testament to the passion and determination of our animal protection movement," said JungAh Chae, executive director of HSI's Korea office.

Dogs are also eaten in China, Vietnam, Indonesia, North Korea and in some African countries. But South Korea's dog meat industry has drawn more attention because of the country's reputation as a cultural and economic powerhouse. It's also the only nation with industrial-scale dog farms. Most farms in South Korea raise about 500 dogs, but one visited by The Associated Press in July had about 7,000.

Farmers were extremely upset by the bill's passage.

"This is a clear case of state violence as they are infringing on our freedom to choose our occupation. We can't just sit by idly," said Son Won Hak, a farmer and former leader of a farmers' association.

Son said dog farmers will file a petition with the Constitutional Court of Korea and hold demonstrations. He said farmers will meet on Wednesday to discuss other steps.

There is no reliable official data on the exact size of South Korea's dog meat industry. Activists and farmers say hundreds of thousands of dogs are slaughtered for meat each year.

The anti-dog meat campaign received a huge boost from the country's first lady, Kim Keon Hee, who has repeatedly expressed her support for a prohibition. She has become the subject of withering criticism and crude insults during demonstrations by farmers.

The legislation doesn't clearly specify how dog farmers and others in the industry will be supported. Agriculture Minister Song Mi-ryung said Tuesday the government will try to formulate reasonable assistance programs for them.

PRISM

Cat flees from owner at truck stop

Nevada: An Illinois trucker was reunited with his cat after the feline fled from his vehicle during a pit stop at a truck stop in Nevada. Chad McIntyre, of Decatur, said his cat, Tyler, often accompanies him on his long-haul drives.

"It's nice that he's lying there in the passenger seat, and yeah, he doesn't talk back, but it's nice to have somebody, something to talk to," McIntyre told KSTU-TV.

McIntyre said he was changing Tyler's litter box when the feline wandered off at a Flying J Truck Stop in Fernley. "I had to deliver to Walmart so I had to leave, and I was gone for about 2 1/2 hours and came right back and started to look for him again," McIntyre said.

Chinese snow park breaks record

China: The Harbin Ice-Snow World attraction in China earned a Guinness World Record for the largest temporary ice and snow theme park.

The park has been an annual attraction in Harbin, Heilongjiang, since 1999, and this year's version was verified by Guinness World Records as covering an area of 8,790,697.3 square feet, making it the largest theme park of its type in the world. The park features more than 2,000 ice and snow sculptures and took a team of more than 10,000 builders more than a month to complete.

A Guinness World Records adjudicator presented officials with a certificate at the China Ice and Snow Tourism Development Forum 2024 in Harbin.

(AP)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1861 – American Civil War: Florida becomes the third state to secede from the Union.

1863 – The Metropolitan Railway, the world's oldest underground railway, opens between Paddington and Farringdon, marking the beginning of the London Underground.

1920 – The Treaty of Versailles takes effect, officially ending World War I for all combatant nations except the United States.

1920 – League of Nations Covenant automatically enters into force after the Treaty of Versailles is ratified by Germany.

1946 – The United States Army Signal Corps successfully conducts Project Diana, bouncing radio waves off the Moon and receiving the reflected signals.

2015 – A traffic accident between an oil tanker truck and passenger coach en route to Shikarpur from Karachi on the Pakistan National Highway Link Road near Gulshan-e-Hadeed, Karachi, killing at least 62 people.

France drops renewable energy targets

AFP
France, Jan. 9

Critics are deriding as a step backward a new French energy bill that favours the further development of nuclear power and avoids setting targets for solar and wind power and other renewables.

France, like other EU countries, aims to achieve carbon neutrality in 2050.

The proposed text, which is slated to go before the cabinet early next month and then be submitted to lawmakers, reaffirms France's commitment to nuclear power to ensure "energy sovereignty".

The country became a leader in nuclear power generation after the 1973 oil crisis, building over 50 such power plants that produced around two-thirds of the country's electricity.

But those reactors are ageing and France has yet to bring the first of a new generation of nuclear power plants online.

The proposed text affirms "the sustainable choice of using nuclear energy as a competitive and carbon-free" source of electricity, and targets the construction of at least six but as many as 14 new reactors to pull off the transition to clean energy and meet climate change goals.



PHOTO: AFP

Steam rises from the cooling towers of the Bugey nuclear power plant in Saint-Vulbas, central France on July 20, 2023.

But the proposed text sets no such targets for building renewable capacity, in particular wind and solar, whereas previous energy laws did.

The Ministry of Energy Transition said "it is false to say that there is no renewables objective" as the government will set the targets itself later.

But that pledge does not satisfy activists and experts.

"It's a terrible step back," said Arnaud Gosse, a lawyer specialising in environmental law.

He recalled that in a 2019 law, parliament stated the desire to debate the share of different energy sources in overall production.

"If you only quantify nuclear power, you do not know the share of non-renewable energies. As a result, nuclear gets prioritised and, depending on remaining coverage needs, non-renewables will be the subject of floating (future) decrees. It's no longer a mix," Gosse said.

To reach its stated ambition of carbon neutrality by 2050 France will have to massively ramp up the production and share of renewables, studies have repeatedly shown.

After years of prevarication, France last year voted through two bills designed to speed up progress on nuclear as well as renewables.

In November, the government put forward initial figures proposing a doubling to 18 GW of offshore wind power in 2035 as well as setting out the annual rate of deployment of solar panels needed to hit 75 GW in 2035, while also aiming for a doubling of onshore wind power capacity to 40 GW in 2035.

Jules Nyssen, president of France's Renewable Energies Union, declared himself "stunned" after discovering that renewables targets did not appear in the draft.

The text promises to make efforts rather than set objectives and uses formulations such as "tending towards a reduction".

For Anne Bringault, energy transition manager of the Climate Action Network, "this is an extremely significant step backwards, and totally inconsistent with European objectives.

"Even if the objectives are raised, we no longer have such a strong commitment to them," she said.

The draft law also drops targets for reducing energy consumption via renovation of buildings.

PM URGED TO ADDRESS CONCERNS OF CONFLICT-AFFECTED FAMILIES

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 9

Families of security personnel who lost their lives in course of the decade-long armed conflict in the country met with Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' on Tuesday, urging him to address their legitimate concerns regarding transitional justice.

During the meeting, they expressed their support to proceed with the Transitional Justice Bill which is presently under consideration in the parliament. They said they are positive towards the Bill as it equally treats those killed by the State and rebel side during the conflict.

On behalf of the conflict-affected families of security personnel, Rita Karki expressed her hope that the incumbent government will profoundly feel pains of conflict-hit community and address their concerns regarding transitional justice.

In response, Prime Minister Dahal assured the families that the Bill does not differentiate between the families of those killed by the State and rebel sides during the conflict. He pledged that there will be no discrimination on these grounds in the future as well. The Prime Minister promised to revise the Bill to accommodate the interests of all affected families as much as possible.



PHOTO: KABITA/TRN

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Defence Purna Bahadur Khadka attending 26th anniversary ceremony of Astro-Council, Nepal in the capital on Tuesday.

RPP'S BISTA TAKES OATH OF SPEAKER IN KOSHI

RSS
Morang, Jan. 9

Chief of Koshi province Parashuram Khapung administered the oath of office to the newly elected speaker of the Provincial Assembly Ambar Bahadur Bista on Tuesday. Province Chief Khapung administered the oath of office and secrecy to Speaker Bista at a special ceremony held at the Office of the Province Chief in Biratnagar.

Chief Minister Kedar Karki, outgoing and former Chief Ministers Hikmat Kumar Karki, Uddhav Thapa and Rajendra Rai, former Speaker, Ministers, Members of the Provincial Assembly, Heads of Security Agencies and political party leaders and cadres were present at the swearing-in ceremony.

Earlier Tuesday, Speaker Bista was elected unopposed in the election held at the Provincial Assembly in accordance with Rule 7 of the Provincial Assembly Rules, 2074 (including first amendment).

Bista is a member of the provincial assembly elected from the Rastriya Prajatantra Party (RPP).

CIAA MOVES SC AGAINST SPECIAL COURT'S VERDICT

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 9

The Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA) has moved the Supreme Court against the Special Court's verdict in relation to three members of the then Tax Settlement Commission.

The CIAA has filed an appeal at the SC against the then Tax Settlement Commission office-bearers including LD (Lumba Dhowj) Mahat, Umesh Prasad Dhakal and Chunamani Sharma stating that the Special Court's decision on penalty against the three was insufficient for the wrongdoings they committed.

Earlier, the CIAA had lodged the case at the Special Court claiming Rs 11.2 billion in fine against the three but the Special Court issued a verdict announcing Rs 4.86 billion in fine to the three. The Special Court had sentenced nine years one month in jail to Chair Mahat and nine years in jail to members Umesh Prasad Dhakal and Chunamani Sharma Dhakal.

The CIAA has shared its reservation in 10 different points on the Special Court's verdict.

COMPLAINTS FILED AGAINST TWO NA CANDIDATES

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 9

Complaints have been filed against two candidates who filed their candidacy for upcoming National Assembly (NA) election.

According to Shaligram Sharma Poudel, Spokesperson at the Election Commission of Nepal, complaints have been registered against Narayan Dutta Bhatt, candidate from the person with disabilities group representing Nepali Congress from Sudurpaschim Province, and Bishnu BK, candidate from Dalit group representing CPN (Maoist Centre) from Karnali Province.

Ramchandra Joshi of CPN (UML) filed a complaint against Bhatt stating that he lacked evidence to prove his physical disability while Hikmat BK of CPN (UML) registered the complaint against candidate BK that his name was in the closed-list of the House of Representatives members' election.

A total of 52 candidates had registered their nominations on Monday for the upper house's election to be held on January 25 for 19 vacant posts.

Bagmati Province to have over 5,000 civil servants

BY RAMMANI DAHAL
Hetauda, Jan. 9

The government of Bagmati Province has approved the creation of 971 new positions, meaning it will now have a total of 5,237 civil servants working in its ministries, departments and subordinate agencies.

The positions were created based on the reports of the organisation and management surveys presented by various ministries, commissions and organisations to the provincial cabinet on various occasions.

Officials believe that the approval of new positions, along with the formation and operation of the Provincial Public Service Commission, will help Bagmati realise administrative federalism.

As per the provincial government, the over 5,000 civil servants will serve in the 12 provincial ministries as well as at the Secretariat of the Provincial Assembly, the Provincial Public Service Commission, the Provincial Treasury Comptroller Office, the Provincial Policy and Planning Commission and the Office of the Chief Attorney.

Nishchal Raj Pandey, secretary at the Office of the Chief Minister and the Council of Ministers, additionally informed that of the total number of positions, 4,873 were permanent posts while the remaining 364 were contract-based non-permanent ones.

The Provincial Public Service Commission has already published vacancies for seventh- and ninth-class positions under various service categories as per the new structure.

At the time of the formation of the provincial government in 2017, Bagmati only had 3,600 positions in its bureaucracy. This had been forcing it to rely on employees deputed by the federal government.

Presently, the province has 200 employees deputed by the centre working with it.

Secretary Pandey told The Rising Nepal that they would go back after the positions they are currently occupying are filled with employees hired by the province.

JN.1, newest variant of COVID-19, highly transmissible: MoHP

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 9

The infection rate of the newest sub-variant of Coronavirus , JN.1, is found to be increasing in Nepal.

According to Dr Rudra Prasad Marasini, Director of the Epidemiology and Diseases Control Division under the Ministry of Health and Population (MoHP), the transmission rate of this new variant from one person to another is higher compared to other variants.

Marasini said, "The transmission rate of JN.1 is higher in the cities since there are more crowds. The fatality rate and complications of the infection are, however, low."

It may be noted that the JN.1 sub-variant was detected in seven of the 16 samples tested in the National Public Health Laboratory on last Monday. The JN.1 is the newest variant of Omicron.

Since the new sub-variant is highly transmissible, the MoHP has urged one and all to exercise precautionary measures in a crowd such as wearing a face mask, maintaining physical distance and keep hands clean by washing frequently among others.

In view of increasing infection rate of the new sub-variant of Coronavirus, the Ministry said that it had been conducting screening of suspected ones in the entry points through the health desks set up there.

Donald Trump returning to court as judges hear arguments on his immunity claim

AP
Washington, Jan. 9

Donald Trump is returning for the first time in months to the federal courthouse in Washington as an appeals court hears arguments Tuesday on whether the former president is immune from prosecution on charges that he plotted to overturn the results of the 2020 election.

The outcome of the arguments carries enormous ramifications both for the landmark criminal case against Trump and for the broader, and legally untested, question of whether an ex-president can be prosecuted for acts committed in the White House. It will also likely set the stage for further appeals before the U.S. Supreme Court, which last month declined a request to weigh but could still get involved later.

A swift decision is crucial for special counsel Jack Smith and his team, who are eager to get the case — now paused pending the appeal — to trial before the November election. But Trump's lawyers, in addition to seeking to get the case dismissed, are hoping to benefit from a protracted appeals process that could delay the trial well past its scheduled March 4 start date, including until potentially after the election.

Smith and members of his prosecution team entered the courtroom and took their seats more than a half hour before arguments were set to begin.

Underscoring the importance to both sides, Trump, the 2024 Republican presidential primary front-runner, intends to attend Tuesday's arguments even though the Iowa caucuses are just one week away and despite the fact that there's no requirement that defendants appear in person for such proceedings. It will be his first court appearance in Washington, one of four cities where he faces criminal prosecutions and potential trials, since his arraignment in August.

He's already signaling that he could use the appearance to portray himself as the victim of a politicized justice system. Though there's no evidence that President Joe Biden has had any influence on the case, Trump's argument could resonate with Republican voters in Iowa as they prepare to launch the presidential nomination process.

"Of course I was entitled, as President of the United States and Commander in Chief, to Immunity," he wrote in a social media post, adding, "I was looking for voter fraud, and finding it, which is my obligation to do, and otherwise running our Country."

Former presidents enjoy broad immunity from lawsuits for actions taken as part of their official White House duties. But because no former president before Trump has ever been indicted, courts have never before addressed whether that protection extends to criminal prosecution.

Trump's lawyers insist that it does, arguing that courts have no authority to scrutinize a president's official acts and decisions and that the prosecution of their client represents a dramatic departure from more than two centuries of American history that would open the door to future "politically motivated" cases. They filed a similar motion on Monday in another criminal case against Trump in Georgia.

Smith's team has said presidents are not entitled to absolute immunity and that, in any event, the acts Trump is alleged in the indictment to have taken — including scheming to enlist fake electors in battleground states won by Biden and pressing his vice president, Mike Pence, to reject the counting of electoral votes on Jan. 6, 2021 — fall far outside a president's official job duties.

"Immunity from criminal prosecution would be particularly dangerous where, as here, the former President is alleged to have engaged in criminal conduct aimed at overturning the results of a Presidential election to remain in office beyond the allotted term," Smith's team wrote in a brief.

"A President who unlawfully seeks to retain power through criminal means unchecked by potential criminal prosecution could jeopardize both the Presidency itself and the very foundations of our democratic system of governance," they added.

Prosecutors say that if Trump's view of the law were to be accepted, a president could get away with steering a lucrative government contract in exchange for a bribe; instructing the FBI director to plant incriminating evidence on a political enemy; or selling nuclear secrets to a foreign adversary.

The case is being argued in the U.S. Court of Appeals for the D.C. Circuit before Judges J. Michelle Childs and Florence Pan, both appointees of Biden, a Democrat, and Karen LeCraft Henderson, who was named to the bench by President George H.W. Bush, a Republican.

It's not clear how quickly the panel will rule, though it has signaled that it intends to work fast. The judges requested that both prosecutors and defense lawyers submit briefs in rapid succession last month, including setting filing deadlines on Saturdays.

U.S. District Judge Tanya Chutkan, who is presiding over the case, rejected the Trump team arguments, ruling on Dec. 1 that the office of the presidency does not confer a "'get-out-of-jail-free pass.'" Trump's lawyers appealed that decision, but Smith's team, determined to keep the case on schedule, sought to leapfrog the appeals court by asking the Supreme Court to fast-track the immunity question and rule in the government's favor. The justices declined, without explanation, to get involved.

The appeal is vital to a broader Trump strategy of trying to postpone the election subversion case until after the November election, when a victory could empower him to order the Justice Department to abandon the prosecution or even to seek a pardon for himself. He faces three other criminal cases, in both state and federal court, though the Washington case is scheduled for trial first.

Trump's lawyers have also cited a constitutional provision against double jeopardy in arguing for immunity, saying that the case concerns similar conduct for which he has already been impeached by the House of Representatives but acquitted by the Senate.

School raises...

Durga Singh Saru, current headmaster, said that they would conduct a detailed study on the issue by calling the members of previous management committee.

Meanwhile, Darlami has registered a complaint at the district administration office stating that the school had done unfair transaction with him.

Mukti Ram Rijal, Assistant Chief District Officer, informed the administration had instructed the District Police Office to coordinate to solve the issue.

He said, "A complaint has been filed. Following it, the Chief District Office has instructed the district police to discuss the matter with both the parties."

'System should...

Certain members suggested making it legally mandatory for individuals holding distinguished posts to show due respect to the Constitution and democracy.

"Some members continue to bypass the meeting regularly have posed challenges in the functioning of the Council," they said, assessing that the mindset that an individual is above the rule hinders the institutionalization of democracy.

Secretary at the Office of the Prime Minister and Council of Ministers, secretary at the Ministry of Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs stressed on the need of a wider participations of members in the meeting to make its functioning smooth and effective.

Committee members highlighted that the aim of the bill is to address potential adversities arising from the dynamic involving various parties within the government and those holding majority positions in the Council. Although the proposed amendment does not differ significantly in substance, it strives for linguistic clarity, it is said.

During the meeting, authority was granted to senior members in the committee representing the Nepali Congress, CPN (UML), CPN (Maoist Centre), and the Rastriya Swatantra Party to collaborate and reach a consensus on the bill. Following the completion of theoretical discussions, the committee has initiated clause-wise deliberations on the proposed amendments.

US and UK say Bangladesh's elections extending Hasina's rule were not credible

AP
Dhaka, Jan. 9

The United States and the United Kingdom said the elections that extended Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina's rule were not credible, free and fair.

Both countries, which have trade and development ties with Bangladesh, also condemned political violence that preceded Sunday's election in which Hasina's party won more than two-thirds of the parliamentary seats while turnout was low and the main opposition party boycotted. "The United States remains concerned by the arrests of thousands of political opposition members and by reports of irregularities on elections day. The United States shares the view with other observers that these elections were not free or fair and we regret that not all parties participated," State Department spokesperson Mathew Miller said from Washington.

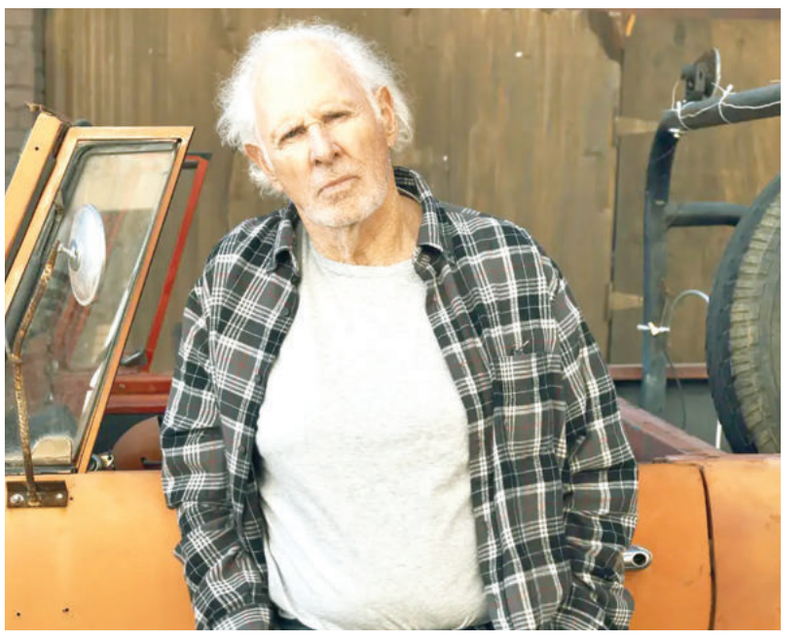
He urged Bangladesh's government to credibly investigate reports of violence and hold those responsible accountable.

The U.K. said the democratic standards were not met consistently in the lead-up to the election.

"Democratic elections depend on credible, open, and fair competition. Respect for human rights, rule of law and due process are essential elements of the democratic process. These standards were not consistently met during the election period. We are concerned at the significant number of arrests of opposition party members before polling day," the UK's Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office said in the statement.

Bruce Dern to appear in 'The World's Happiest Man'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 9



Two-time Oscar-nominated Hollywood actor Bruce Dern is set to appear in Binod Paudel's latest film titled 'Bhuthan' in Nepali and 'The World's Happiest Man' in English.

Dern will share the screen with Nepali actors Dayahang Rai and Hari Bansha Acharya.

Dern, nominated for Oscars for 'Coming Home' (1979) and 'Nebraska' (2013), won the Best Actor award at Cannes for the latter.

The film shall also feature Anuradha Majumdar, Puja Chand-Lama, Richa Ghimire, Joes Pandey, Aditi Pyakurel, Tom Krane and Bimal Subedi.

Rajendra Thakurathi, who has been involved in over 50 Hollywood projects including 'Onward,' 'Smash-hit Barbarian,' and the 'Detective Knight' series, is on board as a producer.

'The World's Happiest Man,' previously selected for the Busan Film Festival in 2019, narrates the struggles of Bhutanese refugees in the US who initially sought refuge in India and later resided in Nepal for several years.

The film, set to be shot in Akron, Ohio and surrounding towns, will be produced in both Nepali and English languages, with a completion target of 2024 and a release scheduled for 2025.

Susan Prajatai will direct the cinematography, and Anjan Khadka serves as the editor.

Star Zhao, the Oscar-winning director of 'La La Land' (2017), serves as an associate producer, as stated in an earlier press release.

In addition to Thakurathi, other primary producers are Amitabh Joshi and Abeeral Thapa, with L.N. Adhikari and Kaushila Khanal Karmacharya as executive producers.

The film is a collaborative effort between America's Mad Monkey Films and Dog Eared Fixture, and Nepal's Awaken Production.

'The World's Happiest Man' participated in the 2019 Busan Asian Project Market under the title 'Akron International.'

Director Paudel is a Nepali filmmaker renowned for his critically acclaimed works. His film 'Bulbul' was selected as Nepal's official entry in the international category at the Oscars in 2019.

Additionally, he secured the Best Director accolade at Nepal's National Film Awards, following a previous win for Best Screenplay for 'Saanghuro' in 2013.

'Dhorpatan' to release on Friday



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan.9

Salpa Films has announced the cinema release of its new documentary 'Dhorpatan', also known internationally as 'No Winter Holidays.'

According to a press release issued by filmmaker Rajan Kathet on Tuesday, the 79-minute film has screened at many prestigious festivals across the world and will be released in Kathmandu on January 12, at the CDC Cinemas at 5 pm.

The film's production started in 2019, and it first world-premiered at Sheffield DocFest, the United Kingdom, in June last year.

It then went to the DMZ International Documentary Film Festival in South Korea and charmed audiences in India at the Dharamshala International Film Festival and Kolkata International Film Festivals, mentioned the press release.

In December last year, it won the Nativa Prize at the AlterNativa Film Awards in Kazakhstan for being 'culturally significant' and was declared the Best Documentary at the Nepal Human Rights International Film Festival 2023.

"We are delighted to bring it home, and we are curious to see what Nepali film lovers will think of this film," said Director/Producer Rajan Kathet.

Paris names a street after David Bowie celebrating music icon's legacy



AP
PARIS, Jan. 9

Paris immortalized late British music icon David Bowie by naming a street after him in the city's southeast on what would have been his 77th birthday on Monday.

The inauguration of rue David-Bowie was first announced in 2020 by Jérôme Coumet, mayor of the 13th arrondissement. Bowie died of cancer in 2016.

The tribute celebrated Bowie's first Paris performance in 1965 — his first outside the United Kingdom — and his lasting impact on music, fashion and culture. Bowie's influence on music, with hits like "Space Oddity" and "Let's Dance," and on fashion, are now permanently recognized in the Paris city landscape.

The inauguration featured a concert and an exhibit.

The street is roughly between the Jardin des Plantes botanical gardens and the National Library.

It is situated between two modern office buildings, including the headquarters of news publications Le Monde and L'Obs, opens onto avenue Pierre-Mendes-France and will connect to a future bridge linking the avenue to boulevard de l'Hopital, near Austerlitz train station and Pitie-Salpetriere Hospital.

The development reflects the ongoing transformation of the district, which now celebrates the legacy of Bowie along with other notable figures.

Golden Globes ratings rebound to 9.4 million viewers, up from 2023 telecast

AP
New York, Jan. 9

Reviews have been poor for Sunday's 81st Golden Globes, but the telecast pulled in an average of 9.4 million viewers, up about 50% from last year, according to CBS.

The ceremony had the benefit of an NFL lead-in, as well as an especially starry gathering that drew Taylor Swift, Oprah Winfrey, Timothée Chalamet, Kylie Jenner, Leonardo DiCaprio and many more. The night's biggest winner, "Oppenheimer," was also a huge ticket-seller, with nearly $1 billion in box office.

But the broadcast hosted by comedian Jo Koy, was slammed by critics for a fumbled opening monologue and a rushed pace throughout that struggled to rekindle the "Hollywood's party of the year"-vibe that the Globes have long fostered.

But more viewers tuned in than they have since before the pandemic. Back in 2020, 18.4 million watched the Globes.

The ratings were a marked improvement over last year's Globes.

That telecast, hosted by Jerrod Carmichael and aired on a Tuesday, attracted 6.3 million viewers, a new low for the ceremony on NBC. At their peak, the Globes often drew closer to 20 million viewers.

Amid the decline of linear television, all award shows have struggled to reach the numbers they once did. But the Globes have been tested especially due to their own actions. After The Los Angeles Times reported that the HFPA had no Black members, Hollywood boycotted the organization and the 2022 Globes were booted off the air. They returned in 2023 on a one-year trial with NBC, but the Globes' network home for decades ultimately dropped the show. After shopping the broadcast around, including to streaming platforms, CBS last month signed on to air Sunday's show.



Sunday's broadcast was a crucial test for the revamped Globes. Following the scandals, the awards were acquired by Eldridge Industries and Dick Clark Productions, which Penske Media owns, and turned into a for-profit venture.

The Hollywood Foreign Press Association was dissolved and a group of some 300 entertainment journalists from around the world was formed to vote on the awards.

CBS also streamed it to Showtime subscribers on Paramount TV+. CBS didn't provide streaming viewership figures but said it was the second-largest live-streamed CBS special event on Paramount+.

Koy, speaking Monday on ABC's "GMA3," acknowledged that he would "be lying" if he said the criticism "doesn't hurt."

"It's a tough room. And it was a hard job, I'm not going to lie," said Koy, who landed the hosting job two weeks before the ceremony. "Getting that gig, and then having the amount of time that we had to prepare — that was a crash course."

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: You can fight the good fight. A motivating fire is heating up under your feet, encouraging you to get going with dreams that you had put on the back burner. There could be obstacles that are standing in your way.

Taurus: Your desire to see the world may be strengthening. It's hard to travel sometimes, as your comfort zone might be unimaginably comfortable! The unfamiliar cultures and people that await you might feel awkward or strange at times.

Gemini: Your emotions can get you where you need to be. Not every situation requires logic and efficiency -- some issues are better handled with sensitivity or spirituality. Perhaps someone in your life needs more of a shoulder.

Cancer: Three isn't a crowd at the moment -- in fact, it's just even better company! Friends can revitalize your soul and inspire you to do more with your life. You might find that the stories that they tell you about their own practices!

Leo: Self-discipline and self-expression can take you far at present. Someone could notice the example that you're setting with your life and see this as an asset to their company, friend group, or even home.

Virgo: A sense of passion can empower your hunt for clarity. You may have been struggling to make a choice or take a risk -- ask yourself if you've been following the advice of others rather than your inner voice.

Libra: Peaceful doesn't currently mean boring. You're not necessarily experiencing huge highs and lows at this time, but you're likely undergoing transformations that will affect your abilities strongly further down the road.

Scorpio: The storms of life might be tossing you to and fro right now! You may encounter problems others could aid with, but it's difficult to ask for help. It's possible that you fiercely guard your emotions and independence.

Sagittarius: Modernized forms of revenue may support your current life. Of course, nothing will happen without your effort, but luckily, you're probably no stranger to hard work.

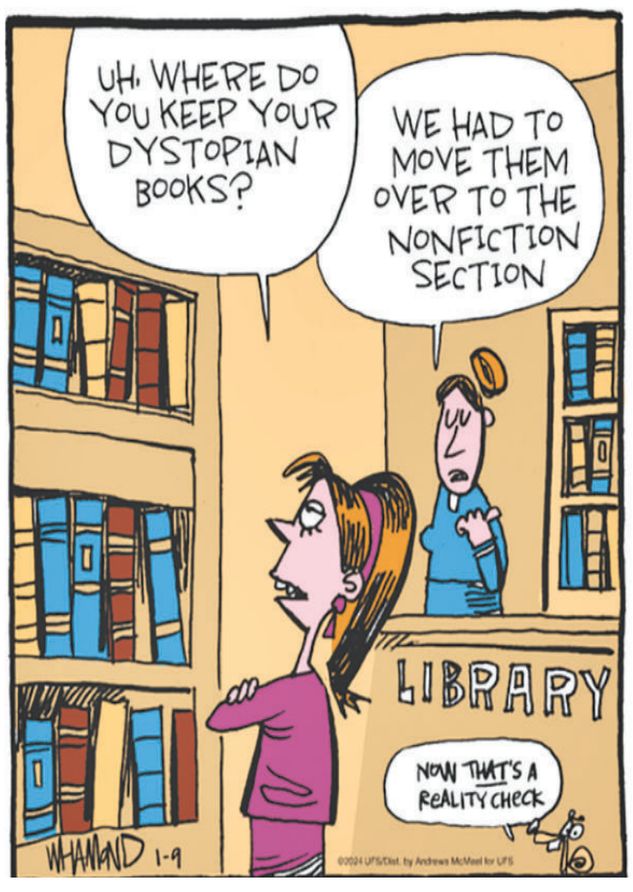
Capricorn: You can show your supporters what they're helping you do. It may be that you've had dreams that weren't coming to fruition for ages, but you're finally seeing the results of the blood, sweat, and tears that you've put into them!.

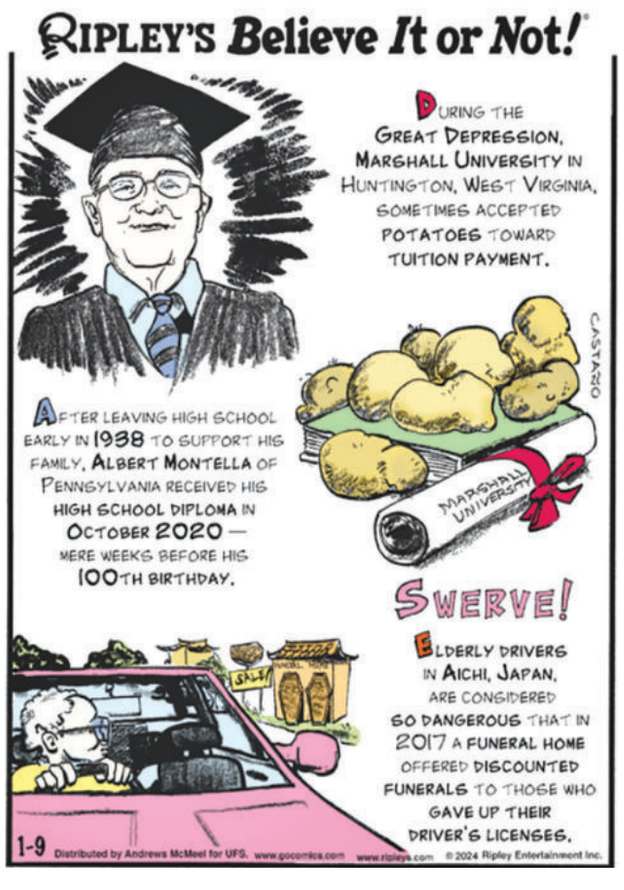
Aquarius: You're the calm in the storm. There may be a lot of disorder in your life, but despite the confusion that's swirling around you, you're able to stay centered and build more stability for those around you.

Pisces: A community could need you to represent them. You possibly belong to that's asking you to act as their spokesperson -- perhaps you're taking part in a conversation that doesn't have a voice from that group.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Man United ease through to 4th round



PHOTO: AP

Manchester United's Bruno Fernandes, centre, celebrates after scoring his side's second goal during the English FA Cup third round match against Wigan Athletic in England.

AP
Wigan, Jan. 9

Manchester United avoided becoming the highest-profile casualty in the third round of the FA Cup by easing past third-tier Wigan with a 2-0 win on Monday.

Portugal internationals Diogo Dalot and Bruno Fernandes — with a penalty — scored United's goals at DW Stadium to set up a match in the last 32 against either Newport County or Eastleigh, two more lower-league teams.

United, which reached the FA Cup final last season before losing to Manchester City, had lost four of its previous six games in all competitions — increasing the pressure on manager Erik ten Hag — but produced a dominant display against a team that was last in the Premier League in 2013. That was the same year Wigan won the FA Cup, beating City in the title match in one of the competition's biggest shocks.Dalot curled in the opening goal in the 22nd minute, finding the far corner with a precise finish from the edge of the area.

Fernandes added the second in the 74th after he had been tripped by Liam Shaw.

There have been no major shocks so far in the third round, though Premier League teams West Ham, Nottingham Forest and Luton were all held to draws at home by lower-division opponents.

City face Tottenham test

Man City will continue its title defense with a trip to Tottenham in the standout match in the draw for the fourth round, which was made just before kickoff of the Wigan-Man United game. There are three other guaranteed all-Premier League matchups: Chelsea vs. Aston Villa, Fulham vs. Newcastle and Sheffield United vs. Brighton.

Wrexham, the fourth-tier Welsh club owned by Hollywood actors Ryan Reynolds and Rob McElhenney, must travel to second-tier Blackburn.

Villarreal eliminated

Villarreal was eliminated on penalties by third-division club Unionistas on Monday in a Copa del Rey match which had been hit the day before by a power outage.

The third-round match was suspended before the start of extra time on Sunday. The teams drew 1-1 in regulation and neither side scored again in extra time on Monday. Unionistas won 7-6 in the shootout to reach the round of 16 when it will host Barcelona.

The only other topflight club to lose to a lower-division club in this round was Las Palmas, which lost 2-0 to second-division team Tenerife on Sunday. Real Betis lost 1-0 to Alaves in a match between first-division clubs on Saturday.

Defending champion Real Madrid advanced past fourth-division team Arandina 3-1 on Saturday, while Atletico Madrid beat third-tier team Lugo 3-1. Barcelona edged fourth-division side Barbastro 3-2 on Sunday.



PHOTO CREDIT: RAJENDRA CHITRAKAR

Dilip Yadav from Nepal Police Club lifted 103kg and set a new national record in men's 55kg clean and jerk at the 26th Men's and 11th Women's National Weightlifting Championship held in Thimi, Bhaktapur on Tuesday. Krishna Kala Bist of the Police broke three records in women's 49kg weightlifting category by lifting 59kg in snatch, 77kg in clean and jerk, and 136 kg in total.

Police, Gandaki join Army, APF in semifinals

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 9

Nepal Police Club and Gandaki Province won their final group-stage matches to book their place in the semi-finals of the 34th National Volleyball Tournament being held in Surkhet.

Nepal Police won its match against Koshi Province while Gandaki won against Karnali Province on Tuesday.

Nepal Police secured a commanding victory against Koshi as the sets concluded with scores of 25-15, 25-19, and 25-11.

Likewise, Gandaki emerged victorious against Karnali Province in a closely contested volleyball showdown. The three sets were intense, all culminating in a 25-21 score.

Nepal APF Club and Tribhuvan Army Club also won their respective final group-stage matches against Bagmati and Madhes on Tuesday to stay at the top of Group A and B respectively.

APF and Army had qualified for the semis from their respective groups with nine points in three matches each. The fourth and final group-stage match was to ensure they remained as table toppers.

APF dominated the match against Bagmati as it won by 25-7, 25-18 and 25-13. On the other hand, Army won against Madhes by 25-20, 25-19 and 25-14.

After the win, Nepal Police and Gandaki also secured their positions as the runner-up of Group A and B respectively.

They will be playing for a place in the finals against the group topper of the opposite group on Wednesday.

Now, APF will play against Gandkai and Army will face Police in the semi-finals on Wednesday to book a place for the finals of the national volleyball tournament.

SNIPPETS

Newlands pitch rated 'unsatisfactory'

Cape Town (AFP): The Newlands pitch on which India beat South Africa in less than two days last week was rated "unsatisfactory" by the International Cricket Council (ICC) on Tuesday. India won by seven wickets in Cape Town on Thursday to level the two-match series in a game that lasted just 107 overs and was the shortest Test to produce a result. On Tuesday, the ICC said that Newlands had received one demerit point. The more serious rating of 'unfit' carries three demerit points. If a venue collects six demerit points in a five-year period it will be suspended from staging international cricket for 12 months. Cricket South Africa can appeal the demerit point.

Japan's Endo retires

Tokyo (AFP): Japan's veteran midfielder Yasuhito Endo on Tuesday announced his retirement after 26 years of his career and joined Gamba Osaka as a coach. "I had a really long and fulfilling 26 years of football life" between 1998 and 2023, Endo said in a video message posted on the club's website. "I never thought I'd play this long," the 43-year-old added.

Endo was in Japan's World Cup squad for three times and was named Asian player of the year in 2009. He won 152 Japan caps, a record. Having spent nearly two decades at Gamba Osaka as a footballer, Endo said he's "very happy" to be back as a coach.

Sri Lanka beat Zimbabwe

Colombo (AP): Janith Liyanage missed out on a century but his gritty 95 was enough to take Sri Lanka to a two-wicket win over Zimbabwe in the second one-day international on Monday. Zimbabwe captain Craig Ervine won the toss and elected to bat first. The decision backfired as his team was dismissed for a modest 208 runs in the 45th over at R. Premadasa Stadium. Sri Lanka lost wickets at regular intervals in its chase but Liyanage's first ODI half-century in his second game and some courageous batting from the lower order helped the hosts reach 211-8 with six balls remaining to take a 1-0 lead in the three-match series. The first game was washed out because of rain.

Franz Beckenbauer, who won the World Cup both as player and coach for Germany, has died at 78

AP
Berlin, Jan. 9

Franz Beckenbauer, who won the World Cup both as player and coach and became one of Germany's most beloved personalities with his easygoing charm, has died. He was 78.

Beckenbauer's death was first announced through a statement from his family to German news agency dpa and then confirmed by the German soccer federation.

"It is with deep sadness that we announce that my husband and our father, Franz Beckenbauer, passed away peacefully in his sleep yesterday, Sunday, surrounded by his family," the family said in its statement. "We ask that we be allowed to grieve in peace and be spared any questions."

The statement did not provide a cause of death. The former Bayern Munich great, who became affectionately known as the "Kaiser" — or "Emperor" — had struggled with health problems in recent years.

Beckenbauer also had to contend with allegations of impropriety in later years. But they did nothing to damage the esteem in which he was held.

"The world of FC Bayern is no longer the way it used to be – suddenly darker, quieter, poorer," the Bavarian powerhouse said on its website.

Beckenbauer was one of German soccer's central figures. As a player, he reimagined the defender's role in soccer and captained West Germany to the World Cup title in 1974 after it had lost to England in the 1966 final. He was the coach when West Germany won the tournament again in 1990, a symbolic moment for a country in the midst of reunification, months after the Berlin Wall fell.

"The 'Kaiser' was one of the best players our sport has ever seen," German soccer federation president Bernd Neuendorf said. "With his lightness, his elegance and his vision, he set standards on the field. ... Franz Beckenbauer leaves a great legacy for the federation and soccer as a whole."

Beckenbauer's death comes just two days after the announcement that Mario Zagallo, the Brazilian who became the first person to win the World Cup as a player and coach, had died at the age of 92. The only other person to achieve that feat is France's Didier Deschamps.

Beckenbauer was also instrumental in bringing the highly successful 2006 World Cup to Germany, though his legacy was later tainted by charges that he only succeeded in winning the hosting rights with the help of bribery. He denied the allegations.



The son of a post official from the working-class Munich district of Giesing, Beckenbauer became one of the greatest players to grace the game in a career that also included stints in the United States with the New York Cosmos in the late 1970s and early 1980s.

Born on Sept. 11, 1945, months after Germany's surrender in World War II, Beckenbauer studied to become an insurance salesman but he signed his first professional contract with Bayern when he was 18.

Beckenbauer personalized the position of "libero," the free-roaming nominal defender who often moved forward to threaten the opponent's goal, a role now virtually disappeared from modern football and rarely seen before his days.



An elegant, cool player with vision, Beckenbauer defined as captain the Bayern Munich side that won three successive European Cup titles from 1974 to 1976.

In his first World Cup as player in 1966, West Germany lost the final to host England as Beckenbauer chased Bobby Charlton around the field having been given the task of marking the England standout.

Four years later, with his arm strapped to his body because of a shoulder injury, Germany lost a memorable semifinal to Italy.

Finally, in 1974 at home, Beckenbauer captained West Germany to the title. Beckenbauer left Bayern for New York in 1977 and later recalled fondly the time spent in the United States.

Beckenbauer missed the 1978 World Cup because the Germans decided not to invite players playing abroad. He returned to Germany in 1980, spent two seasons with Hamburg — and won another Bundesliga championship, his fifth — before returning for a final season at the Cosmos.

Although he had never coached before, Beckenbauer was hired to revive West Germany in 1984 after a flop at the European Championship.

West Germany made it to the final of the 1986 World Cup, losing to Diego Maradona's Argentina in Mexico City. Although West Germany failed to win the 1988 Euros title at home, it went to the final of the 1990 World Cup and defeated Argentina in the final in Rome, another highlight in the year after the fall of the Berlin Wall.

Beckenbauer retired from the West Germany job after coaching the team to the 1990 World Cup triumph. The Berlin Wall had fallen the year before and Germany was in the process of reunifying after the Cold War. The final was the last tournament game played by a West Germany-only team.

He didn't have much success at coaching Marseille, but won the Bundesliga title with Bayern in 1994 and the UEFA Cup in 1996, both after taking over as coach late in the season. He later became Bayern's president, until leaving most functions when he turned 65 in 2010.

WEATHER

Wednesday

Sunrise at 6:56 am, Sunset at 5:26 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Wednesday)

Partly cloudy in Koshi Province along with the hilly regions of Gandaki Province and mainly fair in in the rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 17-19 Rain Probability: 0%

Tuesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	18.1	2.9	0.0
Dipayal	23.6	3.5	0.0
Dhangadi	19.2	10.8	0.0
Birendranagar	20.8	4.7	0.0
Nepalgunj	16.5	10.0	0.0
Jumla	16.7	-6.1	0.0
Ghorahi	21.0	5.3	0.0
Pokhara	19.8	8.9	0.0
Bhairahawa	14.8	9.0	0.0
Simara	19.8	6.5	0.0
Kathmandu	17.7	4.5	0.0
Okhaldhunga	18.7	7.5	0.0
Taplejung	17.4	6.2	0.0
Dhankuta	22.6	8.4	0.0
Biratnagar	21.2	11.5	0.0
Jomsom	11.1	-4.0	0.0*
Dharan	22.8	11.5	0.0*
Lumle	16.3	5.2	0.0*
Janakpur	21.6	10.6	0.0*
Jiri	16.0	-0.3	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 10, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.69	Rs. 133.29
Euro	1	Rs. 145.09	Rs. 145.75
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.74	Rs. 169.50
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 155.96	Rs. 156.66
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 88.81	Rs. 89.21
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 99.23	Rs. 99.68
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.72	Rs.100.17
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.21	Rs. 9.25
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.52	Rs. 18.60
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.38	Rs. 35.54
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.40	Rs. 36.56
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.79	Rs. 3.81
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.13	Rs. 36.29
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.58	Rs. 28.70
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.05	Rs. 10.10
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.94	Rs. 13.00
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.45	Rs. 19.54
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.89	Rs. 17.06
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.68	Rs. 433.63
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.95	Rs. 353.54

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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